

# Are Women’s Wings Barriers to Women’s Political Advancement?

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September 1, 2026

## Abstract

Women’s wings are present in nearly 40 percent of parties worldwide. They provide women with pathways into politics and yet, there is no correlation between the presence of a women’s wing and women’s electoral candidacy across party types and electoral systems. Why does a seemingly inclusionary institution fail to advance women’s political careers in practice? I argue that women’s wings enable women’s political entry but stymie their advancement in parties because women’s wings occupy a second-tier status within the party organization. An organizational division of labor leaves women’s wing members unable to develop the vital networks and sociopolitical capital that party elites prioritize during promotion and candidacy decisions. As a result, women’s wing members experience lower organizational mobility and electoral candidacy, relative to women in the main party organization and male members of party wings. I draw on 106 elite interviews and an original survey of 1,054 party elites from two of India’s largest political parties to substantiate these claims. This study suggests that ostensibly gender-egalitarian institutions can institutionalize discrimination by creating parallel, unequal career tracks that exclude women from centers of power.

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<sup>†</sup>The author thanks Navya Singh for excellent field research assistance and coordinating data collection. The author thanks Quest Research and Development and the survey team, particularly Sumit, Sharad, Bhumika, and Manish, for helping with the data collection effort. She also thanks Leonardo Arriola, Adam Auerbach, Kirk Bansak, Pradeep Chhibber, Amanda Clayton, Tanushree Goyal, Alyssa René Heinze, Vanessa Navarro Rodriguez, Gareth Nellis, Diana O’Brien, Vibeke Wang, Stephanie Zonzein, and the participants of the Center for the Politics of Development workshop, the Conference of Graduate Research on Contemporary South Asia at Brown University, MPSA 2026, the 2026 CASI PE Workshop at the University of Pennsylvania, EGEN-SUCCESS Workshop in Bergen, European Conference on Politics and Gender in Newcastle, and European Political Science Society Conference and Pre-Conference Workshop on the Politics of South Asia in Belfast for providing valuable feedback. The study was supported by Global, International, and Area Studies (UC Berkeley), SurveyCTO Primary Data Collection Grant, Bhattacharya Graduate Research Fellowship, and the James Goldgeier Fellowship for International Research. The study was approved by UC Berkeley Institutional Review Board (Protocol IDs: 2025-04-18565, 2023-11-16922).

# Introduction

Political parties around the world have increasingly institutionalized women’s inclusion through the creation of women’s wings, caucuses, and associations. Today, nearly 40 percent of parties formally recognize such an organization within their statutes (Scarrow, Webb, and Poguntke 2022).<sup>1</sup> Yet, there appears to be no correlation between the presence of a women’s wing and the share of women nominated as candidates by a party across electoral systems and party types.<sup>2</sup> It is puzzling that women’s wings do not seem to facilitate women’s advancement into positions of partisan power, despite their stated purpose of increasing the descriptive and substantive representation of women.<sup>3</sup> Why are women’s wings unable to generate meaningful pathways into leadership and candidacy within political parties?

Existing work has established that parties are deeply gender-unequal institutions, where women continue to be outnumbered and outranked by men among rank-and-file members, elites, and candidates. Women are not recruited to join political parties, perform meaningful labor, transition into party leadership, or become candidates as often as men (Bjarnegård 2013; Crowder-Meyer 2013; Fox and Lawless 2010; Norris and Lovenduski 1994; Piscopo 2019). This literature offers elite behavior and the pipelines into politics as explanations for gender inequalities in parties (Bjarnegård and Kenny 2015; Caul 1999; Kenny and Verge 2016; Kunovich and Paxton 2005; Martínez i Coma and Lago 2022; Thomsen and King 2020). But existing scholarship falls short in explaining the paradox of inclusion posed by women’s wings, which are formed voluntarily by political parties. While bringing women into the partisan fold, women’s wings are unable to translate inclusion into political leadership in the party. In this paper, I offer an explanation that centers on the distribution of power within and the structure of the party organization itself. In doing so, I show how an ostensibly gender-egalitarian institution,

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<sup>1</sup>This is likely an undercount of the number of parties with women’s wings since the database does not include many Asian and African countries, such as India, where many parties have an official sub-organization for women.

<sup>2</sup>See Appendix A.

<sup>3</sup>For example, the world’s largest political party, India’s Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), describes its women’s wing as a vehicle for creating “equal opportunities for social, *political* [emphasis added] and economic growth” (BJP 2025).

designed to improve women’s political inclusion, functionally acts as a barrier to their advancement.

I apply the concept of the “glass wall” to women’s wings to explain how they enable women’s political entry but limit their organizational mobility and candidacy by creating two unequal parallel career paths in the party. Using theory grounded in over seven months of extensive fieldwork in India, I argue that women’s wings fail to advance women’s political careers because they occupy a second-tier status within the party organization. For parties, women’s wings’ main purpose is to mobilize women voters, not to act as incubators for political leadership. Women’s wing members, therefore, perform tasks specific to women’s vote mobilization or activism surrounding women’s issues. But consequential party work, such as strategic planning during elections, decision-making around candidate selection, or even service delivery to constituents, remains concentrated among members of the main party organization. This organizational division of labor leaves women’s wing members unable to develop the vital networks and sociopolitical capital that party elites prioritize during promotion and candidacy decisions. As a result, women’s wing members experience lower organizational mobility and electoral candidacy, relative to women in the main party organization and male members of party wings.

Using a mixed-methods approach, I provide evidence for the theory from India, home to some of the largest political parties and women’s wings in the world. I rely on qualitative evidence from 106 in-depth interviews with politicians and political consultants conducted between 2023 and 2026 in India, as well as insights from observing the Delhi state-election campaign in 2025. Quantitatively, I draw on data from an original in-person survey that featured an embedded forced-choice conjoint experiment. Through sustained fieldwork and trust-building with party officials, I secured rare access to a population that remains difficult to survey. The survey was administered to 1,054 post-holding political elites from two of India’s largest parties, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). The survey captures novel measures of politicians’ career trajectories, decision-making, and ambition, allowing me to present descriptive and causal

evidence for limited intra-party mobility for women's wing members.

Descriptively, I find four striking patterns of political entry and promotion. First, women are twice as likely to begin their party leadership careers in the women's wing as the main party organization, suggesting that women's wings do offer women a pathway into politics. Second, women's wing members are 1.5 times less likely to be promoted into the main party organization, relative to men in party wings (such as youth wing and caste-based wings), indicating lower lateral organizational mobility into positions of real authority—what I describe as the glass wall separating women's wings from the main party organization. Third, women's wing members are 2 times less likely to receive promotions in rank or administrative level within the women's wing itself, relative to women in the main party organization, highlighting lower vertical organizational mobility. Fourth, women's wing members are also 2.3 times less likely to become electoral candidates, relative to women in the main party organization. This is particularly salient because baseline rates of women's candidacy are already very low—only 10 percent of national and state election candidates in India are women ([PRS 2023](#)).

Through causal, descriptive, and qualitative evidence, I show that women's wing members perform different tasks in the party, relative to their main party organization peers. Differences in their labor translate into gaps in their political networks and important sociopolitical capital, such as mobilization capacity and party leadership experience. Using results from the conjoint experiment and corroborative descriptive findings, I show that the promotion criteria used by party elites overlap with the sociopolitical capital women's wing members cannot develop. I find six traits that are strong predictors of promotion and what elites expect of leaders in the main party. These are the ability to deliver services to voters, financial resources, networking and mobilization capacity, party loyalty, and previous partisan leadership experience. By examining elites in the sample along these criteria, I show that women in the wing fare worse than women in the main party organization. Women in the wing have significantly lower quality political networks and lower quality and quantity of partisan leadership experience, and are significantly more likely to toe the party line, compared to their counterparts in the main party.

I then provide evidence against two key alternative explanations: selection into party sub-organizations and lack of political ambition. First, I show that even though elite male networks predict women’s leadership in the main party at higher rates, gaps in promotion and candidacy persist for women’s wing members even after controlling for networks prior to entry. In other words, even though selection influences women’s pathways into the party, women’s wings do not act as an equalizing force. Rather, they reinforce inequalities between elite and non-elite women. This finding is bolstered by the fact that men in party wings do not experience a similar glass wall; for them, party wings act as “stepping stones” into the main party organization, rather than a silo. Second, I demonstrate that women’s wing members express equally high rates of ambition for promotion as their peers in the main party organization, particularly for positions in the main party as opposed to the women’s wing. Thus, aspiration for career advancement is not a reason for their lower organizational mobility or candidacy.

Taken together, these results show that women’s wings are a paradox of inclusion by design. While bringing more women into the party, their position and role in the party organization excludes women from the center of power, the main party organization. This work has implications for research on institutions, gender, and party politics. First, it highlights that gender-egalitarian institutions can reinforce, instead of rupturing, inequalities. As seen in the case of gender quotas, institutions alone cannot facilitate women’s political representation ([Amar, Bamezai, and Kumar 2025](#); [Heinze, Brulé, and Chauchard 2025](#); [Thomas, Hankla, Banerjee, and Banerjee 2024](#)). They require concurrent transformations in elite behavior and structural conditions ([Heinze 2025](#)). In the case of gender quotas, cooptation by male elites prevents women from exercising meaningful political power. In this paper, I demonstrate that women’s wings fail to advance women’s political careers because the discrimination against women is institutionalized within the party organization itself. Second, it sheds light on a potential source of positive change—the women’s wings themselves. Existing literature shows that women’s wings do facilitate women’s political entry and help advocate for career advancement of women ([Goyal 2024a,2](#)). The challenge arises in transforming the roles assigned to women’s

wing members, facilitating transitions into the main party organization, and conferring the benefits of inclusion on all women, not simply the elite and networked. Efforts towards meaningful political inclusion and power for all women will require interventions addressing these challenges.

This paper offers three main contributions to work on gender, parties, and institutions. First, it shows how and why an understudied institution of formal inclusion with global relevance—women’s wings in political parties—fails to advance women’s political careers. It adds to a growing body of evidence that shows how institutions that are gender-egalitarian on paper, such as quotas, can reinforce political inequalities. Second, by examining promotions within party institutions, it contributes a novel explanation for women’s absence from top party leadership and candidacy ([Barnes and O’Brien 2025](#); [Smith, Cirone, Teele, Cox, and Fiva 2026](#)). This explanation is entirely consistent with existing scholarship that finds women active in local politics ([Goyal 2024a,2](#)) and absent in higher office. The paper also makes a key empirical contribution. It provides data from difficult-to-access actors—party elites—who are simultaneously aspirants for promotions and gatekeepers of promotions for others. Much of the gap in understanding organizational hierarchy exists because access to selection committees where promotion decisions are made is immensely difficult for party outsiders. By surveying party elites who are decision makers, I effectively open the black box of how parties select who advances. Comprehensive data on career trajectories, political experiences, political ambition, and promotion preferences allows me to paint a holistic picture of (a) how elites experience party gatekeeping themselves and (b) how they contribute to this gatekeeping based on their own gender and political identities.

## Theoretical Perspectives

Women’s absence from top leadership positions in parties and electoral candidacy has been attributed to women’s absence in the pipeline into politics, elite gatekeeping and cooptation of institutions designed to promote women’s political inclusion, and gendered

responsibilities within the party. This work suggests that women are often missing from careers that feed into politics (Thomsen and King 2020), lack ambition to enter politics (Fox and Lawless 2004; Lawless 2012), or are not recruited into politics (Crowder-Meyer 2013; Fox and Lawless 2010; Norris and Lovenduski 1994). Even when institutions, such as quotas, are designed to facilitate women’s inclusion in politics, they are coopted by male elites unwilling to cede power (Amar et al. 2025; Chauchard, Brulé, and Heinze 2025; Heinze et al. 2025; Karekurve-Ramachandra and Sood 2024). Once women surpass the entry barrier, a gendered division of party labor has negative downstream consequences on electoral candidacy (Curtin, Kerby, and Dowding 2023; Goodwin, Bates, and McKay 2021; Taflaga and Kerby 2020). Party elites who make decisions surrounding candidacy or leadership may gatekeep women out of positions of authority (Bjarnegård and Zetterberg 2019; Folke and Rickne 2016; Kenny and Verge 2016).

While offering critical perspectives explaining women’s underrepresentation in politics, this body of work leaves two parts of the story underspecified: the structure of party organizations and intra-party organizational mobility. Scholars have called for bringing a gendered perspective to the study of political parties as institutions (Kenny and Verge 2016; Verge 2015). Viewing political parties from a feminist institutionalism perspective can help unlock how institutional barriers are embedded within party structures and interactions between sub-organizations of a political party (Kenny 2007; Mackay, Kenny, and Chappell 2010). Simultaneously, political science research has emphasized the gendered barriers to electoral candidacy and elected office, perhaps at the expense of non-elected political leadership. Recent work has noted the importance of formal positions within political parties, both as stepping stones in the ladder towards candidacy and as positions to effect changes in recruitment and selection (Auerbach and Thachil 2018,2; Auerbach, Thachil, and Singh 2025; Goyal 2024a,2; Gulzar, Pathak, Thompson, and Tóth 2024). Therefore, unpacking how elites allocate formal positions has significant implications for the gendered distribution of power within the political party.

In this paper, I bring together work on gender and politics with the literature on party politics to offer an explanation for why women’s wings fail to advance women’s political

careers.

## Women's Wings and the Political Glass Wall

I argue that women's wings enable political entry but effectively stymie women's political advancement within the party. Political parties are divided into the main party organization, which is the central decision-making body, and party wings, which include several identity-based sub-organizations (such as the women's wing, youth wing, student wing, etc.). In this structure, I argue that women's wings occupy a second-tier status within the party organization. Members of the women's wing are tasked with mobilizing the women's vote or protesting on women's issues, leaving consequential decision-making, strategic planning, and service delivery to individuals in the main party organization. This organizational division of labor leaves women's wing members unable to develop the sociopolitical capital that party elites prioritize in promotion and candidacy decisions. As a result, women's wing members experience fewer promotions into the main party organization, fewer promotions to higher positions within the wing itself, and lower rates of electoral candidacy. Below, I describe the argument in detail using qualitative evidence from over seven months of fieldwork with political parties in Delhi, India.

Women's wings offer a pathway into partisan life for a vast majority of women. Women politicians and activists are more likely to recruit other women into politics, particularly through women's wings (Goyal 2026). They provide a space where women can be involved in politics and work for the party, often framed as service, alongside other women (Bedi 2017; Chowdhury 2024). Several women politicians I interviewed suggested joining the women's wings of parties as the first step to entering politics. Because the main party organizations are dominated by men, women's wings become a gender-norm compliant pathway into the party. A politician's daughter, a bureaucrat herself, said, "It is easier to convince your family if you say you will join the women's wing of a party."<sup>4</sup> A male leader in one political party emphasized that "women's wings should exist because that's a soft entry. At least they are entering [through the wing]."<sup>5</sup> Thus, the presence of

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<sup>4</sup>Interview Subject 7, interviewed by author on January 11, 2024, in Delhi, India.

<sup>5</sup>Interview Subject 52, interviewed by author on November 15, 2025, in California, USA.

women’s wings themselves is not the problem; it is the position these wings occupy within the larger party structure and the responsibilities their members are tasked with that produce blockages in women’s career advancement.

Party organizations establish women’s wings to mobilize women voters for the party during elections, despite claiming broader goals of descriptively and substantively representing women. Consequently, women in the women’s wing occupy different roles and perform different functions than members of the main party organization. The party structure places women’s wings below the main party organization and institutionalizes the second-tier status of these wings. Women’s wing leaders effectively report to their main party counterparts (BJP 2012). While women’s wing members are surrounded by other women, women in the main party organization are embedded in elite circles that are primarily male, allowing them opportunities to expand their political networks. Consequential decisions are made within the main party organization and relayed to the women’s wing. When candidates are chosen during elections, elites in the main party have a greater say in formation of lists than leaders in the wing (Sarkar 2024). Describing the role of the women’s wing in the Indian National Congress, a leader stated, “Mahila Congress takes the forefront at the women related issues...otherwise the DCC [District Congress Committee] takes the lead...When you talk about political decision-making, they’re not taken into consideration that much. They don’t hold much authority.”<sup>6</sup>

These dynamics were reflected in my interactions with women party workers during fieldwork. While attending a campaign event for the Bharatiya Janata Party on January 22, 2025, in Delhi, I interviewed two different women. The first woman, Asha, was the vice-president in the main party’s district committee and the second woman, Jyoti, was the general secretary of the women’s wing district committee.<sup>7</sup> Asha sat up front with the male leaders of the party, including the incumbent state legislator who was fighting for reelection. Jyoti sat with other women leaders several rows behind Asha and the male leaders. Later when I interviewed Asha, several male politicians walked through the office and spoke with her, clearly well acquainted with her. She spoke with authority

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<sup>6</sup>Interview Subject 12, re-interviewed on January 26, 2026 (remotely). Lightly edited for clarity.

<sup>7</sup>Names changed for anonymity.

over the work she did for the party and was confident she would one day be chosen as a candidate during elections. Jyoti, on the other hand, said “Not everyone gets a ticket, only one person [can], we can’t get angry about it,” settling for working for the party despite wanting more recognition for her efforts.

The organizational division of labor should theoretically affect the promotion and candidacy opportunities of other party wing members (Jalali, Silva, and Costa 2024; Stockemer and Anlar 2024), who are largely men. On paper, their roles and responsibilities are similar to those of women’s wings. They are expected to mobilize voters, represent the interests of their groups, and bridge representation gaps between citizens and parties for their identity groups. However, there are three reasons why members of other party wings may still experience higher levels of organizational mobility relative to women’s wing members. First, homosocial networks help men maintain dominance in politics (Bjarnegård 2013). Even when men join a political party via a party wing, a rare instance to begin with, homosocial ties allow them to cut across party wings to form relationships with male elites in the male party organization. Therefore, despite occupying a less important position in the party structure, party wings’ members can negotiate relevance through their informal ties to male elites in the main party organization (Jalali et al. 2024). Second, despite a similar organizational mandate as women’s wings, male-dominated party wings often act as stepping stones towards leadership in the main party organization. Speaking of men in the youth and student wings of the party, a party leader said,

“They are, you know, considered as a natural hire to the district post, natural hire to the state post. You know, you have just served your time in [the student wing], what will you do next? You will join the [youth wing]. You served your time in [the youth wing], you become the general secretary, now you become the district vice president. This is the natural progression that is not available to women, strangely.”<sup>8</sup>

This variation may arise because party wings, other than women’s wings, bestow ad-

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<sup>8</sup>Interview Subject 12, re-interviewed on January 26, 2026 (remotely). Lightly edited for clarity.

vantages unique to them upon their members. Student wing members can participate in electoral politics at the university-level. They are able to gain the political experience that makes them valuable to a party—campaigning, setting agendas, mobilizing voters, and even running for office. In one Indian party, youth wings select their leaders through internal elections, but the same process does not apply to leadership selection in the women’s wing, where the appointment occurs top-down. Members of caste-based wings may experience further mobility because caste remains a salient factor in assessing “winnability” of candidates and in the vote mobilization calculus for a party (Singh 2023). Third, exacerbating all this may be overt caste-based or statistical discrimination against women politicians. Although gender bias is hard to detect empirically, qualitative evidence suggests the bias is present among male party leaders. Expressing frustration over women’s exclusion from positions of power despite their significant presence in the party, a female party leader said,

“There are a lot of women in the sangathan [organization] and in morchas [wings]. In the day to day, women are not included in the decision-making, strategic planning. Women are not seen as equals to men, unless they are related to a political family or someone of note. The problem is with men, not the party—they make women do all the work but then never make them the face of the party or the leader of the party.”<sup>9</sup>

When asked if all party wing members face similar disadvantages in organizational mobility, a senior male leader replied, “Yes, but women will have more in every wing. The disadvantage is layered. One layer is you are not in main wing. Another biggest layer is if you are women. Otherwise everything is the same. There is a woman repellent mindset.”<sup>10</sup>

Whether it is the organizational division of labor, gender bias, or a combination of the two, these dynamics culminate in women’s wing members being unable to develop elite networks in the main party organization and the sociopolitical capital necessary for

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<sup>9</sup>Interview Subject 24, interviewed by author on August 13, 2024, in Uttar Pradesh, India. Lightly edited for clarity.

<sup>10</sup>Interview Subject 52, interviewed by author on November 15, 2025, in California, USA.

signaling promotion and candidacy viability. Prior research demonstrates that certain traits favor politicians in promotion and candidacy decisions. These include networks within the party, ability to deliver services to constituents and mobilize voters, previous party leadership positions, financial resources, and party loyalty (Auerbach and Thachil 2023; Auerbach et al. 2025; Bjarnegård and Kenny 2015; Chaudhury 2022; Clayton and Zetterberg 2021; Singh 2023). This is precisely the sociopolitical capital that women’s wing members are unable to develop as leaders in the wing—mobilization limited to women’s voters (Goyal 2024b), women-centric networks in the wing, fewer financial resources to fund campaigns, less procedural knowledge and experience to deliver services (Auerbach, Singh, and Thachil 2024), and modest experience with decision-making or strategic planning (Sarkar 2024).

The result of this institutional disparity is lower organizational mobility for women’s wing members in three distinct ways. First, women’s wing members are seldom promoted into the main party organization, akin to a “glass wall.” Much like the proverbial glass ceiling where women can see male counterparts climbing to the top, women’s wing members can see members of the main party organization on the other side of the horizontal divide progressing in their careers. Two different party leaders estimated that between 10 to 30 percent of women’s wing members in their party were promoted into the main party organization.<sup>11</sup> Women politicians recognize the difference in prestige and importance of the main party versus the women’s wing. For instance, a member of the All India Mahila Congress (women’s wing of the Indian National Congress) said, “Women need to be active in the main party not just the Mahila Congress. They need to work in the block, district... learn through that experience.”<sup>12</sup> When asked why women would want roles in the main party organization, a male senior leader in the Aam Aadmi Party said,

“You know why this happens, it’s because women can see that all the decisions are happening in the main wing, they are running the show so they want to be closer to the group that is running the show. Which means, the whole

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<sup>11</sup>Interview Subjects 52 and 12, re-interviewed on January 26, 2026 (remotely).

<sup>12</sup>Interview Subject 20, interviewed by author on August 5, 2024, in New Delhi, India.

process is not inclusive enough to account for women. You are dangling the prize in front of them but giving them small gifts... I will think I want the prize [position in the main party]. When this happens, it creates a sense of superiority in their mind that people in the main wing are superior to us, we are inferior and it is important for us to go there.”<sup>13</sup>

Second, women’s wing members experience less upward mobility within the wing itself. There is less organizational churn inside the women’s wing, meaning that members remain in their positions for longer tenures and are promoted to higher ranks (e.g., moving from secretary to president) or administrative levels (e.g., ward to district level) less often. Third, because formal positions in the party are an important consideration in candidacy decisions for elites ([Auerbach and Thachil 2023](#)), lack of promotion to party leadership roles has enduring negative consequences for women’s wing members’ electoral candidacy ([Curtin et al. 2023](#); [Goodwin et al. 2021](#); [Taflaga and Kerby 2020](#)).

Cumulatively, the argument proposed here generates a few observable implications that I test empirically below. First, I expect that women are more likely to begin their partisan leadership careers inside the women’s wing, relative to men who are more likely to begin their careers in the main party organization. Second, women’s wing members should have lower sociopolitical capital than women in the main party organization. Third, this capital should overlap with criteria prioritized by elites in promotion decisions. Fourth, I expect that women’s wing members will be promoted into the main party organization less frequently than male members of party wings. I also expect that women’s wing members will be less likely to be promoted to higher ranks and administrative levels or to electoral candidacy, relative to women in the main party organization.

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<sup>13</sup>Interview Subject 52, interviewed by author on November 15, 2025, in California, USA.

# Empirical Context

## Political Party Organizations in India

Political parties in India comprise rank-and-file members, appointed post-holding leaders (or party elites), and elected representatives. While the strength and density of the organization vary across parties and across time for a single party ([Chhibber, Jensenius, and Suryanarayan 2014](#)), it typically spans multiple administrative levels and has several wings. Figure 1 shows a simplified version of the most expansive party organization structure for a national political party. In the top row are the various administrative levels of the party organization. Typically, a political party will have “committees” at each of these levels - one national committee, a state committee for each state they have a presence in, a district committee for all districts in each state, an assembly constituency level committee for all assembly constituencies in a state, and so on.

Within each of these committees, the party is divided into the main party organization and its wings. These wings are usually either identity- (such as gender or caste) or occupation-based (such as trade or farmers’ wing). Wings are typically created for the political inclusion of the group within the party and to represent the interests of the group in the party. The main party organization is the central decision-making authority, while the party wings report to and execute directives from the parent body. A senior Indian party leader compared these wings to focus groups:

“The purpose of focus groups is that there are certain issues specific to that group and when that group is formed it is expected that [the] group will talk about issues pertaining to themselves and they will come up with the solutions or they will take the issues to higher ups in the party, so that the party can address them and those who are affected can be brought along. This is why women’s wings, [Scheduled Caste, Scheduled Tribe, Other Backward Castes] wings are made – so that [Other Backward Castes’] issues can be talked about in a focused manner and find a solution or raise the issues, so the group can

[join] the party.”<sup>14</sup>

The notion of bringing group-specific issues to the party and the group being brought along with the party can be understood as the substantive and descriptive aspects of representation for the group within the party.

In each wing at each administrative level, the party appoints leaders, who make up the third row in Figure 1. Elected politicians exist at three levels: ward (municipal councillors or *Nigam Parshads*), state (members of the legislative assembly or *Vidhayaks*), and national (members of parliament or *Sansads*). Elected politicians can be understood as being situated above the president at the corresponding admin level. This is because candidacy and being elected are often the goal for many politicians and a key function of the party apparatus is to get candidates elected. A full list of party positions, created through iterative interviews with party leaders and political strategists, in a committee can be found in Appendix D. In joining a political party, party members with political ambition can have three goals: (a) to become a party leader, (b) to advance in the party hierarchy by being promoted upwards and laterally from a wing to the main party organization, and (c) to become an electoral candidate.

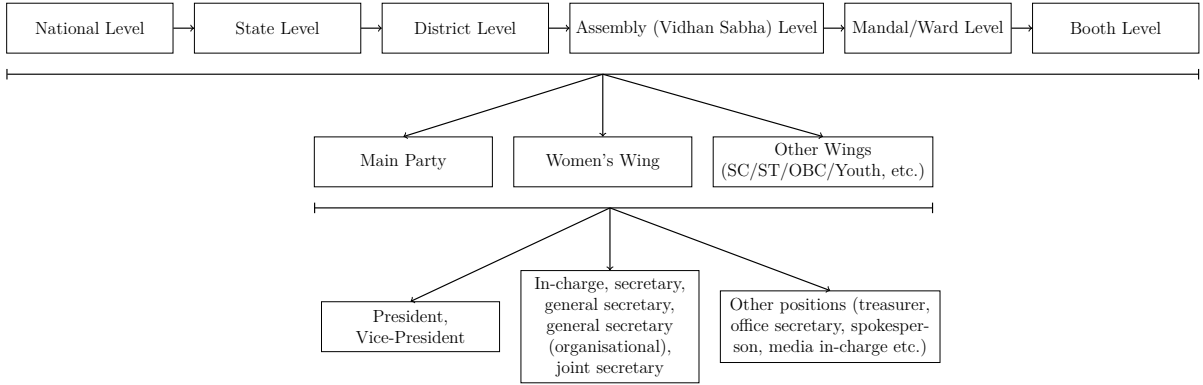


Figure 1: Party Organization Structure: Hierarchy, Wings, and Positions

## Women’s Wings in Delhi’s Parties: A Brief History

Political parties establish women’s wings to articulate their concerns and interests, mobilize women as a voting constituency during elections, and increase their representation

<sup>14</sup>Interview Subject 52, interviewed by author on November 15, 2025, in California, USA.

within the party. The origins, degree of institutionalization in the party hierarchy, and functions of women’s wings vary across political parties. While several parties in India have women’s wings, below I briefly describe the wings of the three main parties in Delhi: the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), and the Indian National Congress (INC).

Following significant electoral defeat in the 1984 national election, the BJP overhauled its party organization. It decided to broaden its electoral base to various minority groups and consequently, established various *morchas* (wings) and cells in the party (Kumar Malhotra and Jaitli 2006; Yadav and Patnaik 2022). These wings “articulated the problems of their respective fields, helped in policy formulation and in mobilising the field...also launched movements and agitations from time to time” (Kumar Malhotra and Jaitli 2006, p.22). The women’s wing, or *mahila morcha*, was specifically meant to help “women participate in politics and work on women-related issues...ensure that women do not hesitate to join the political workspace” (Yadav and Patnaik 2022, p.50). Though each *morcha* would comprise members only of its own group, “they were not meant to compartmentalize the party but to create channels to let different groups of people into the BJP” (Yadav and Patnaik 2022, p.50). Today, the BJP *Mahila Morcha* targets the social, political, and economic development of women (BJP 2025) and spans the various administrative levels of the party organization.

The Aam Aadmi Party, on the other hand, has a less institutionalized women’s wing. As a newer party established only in 2012, its party organization (and therefore, women’s wing) is relatively thinner and more informal. For instance, the party constitution provides details on the broader organization structure of the party but it does not mention any party wings or their relationship to the main party organization (AAP 2021). However, fieldwork revealed a thicker party organization than its constitution suggests. Party leaders were appointed in the main party as well as the women’s wing at the ward, district, state assembly constituency, national assembly constituency, and state level. Moreover, in several press releases around elections, the party signaled its intent to develop women’s wing leaders. It assigned them tasks to mobilize women’s groups and conducted lead-

ership training ([AAP 2024,2](#)). Party documents suggest that the women’s wing role is largely confined to mobilizing women voters and dealing with women-related issues.

While not the empirical focus of this paper, the Indian National Congress’s women’s wing, *All India Mahila Congress* (AIMC), is one of the oldest among Indian parties. The AIMC was established as a frontal organization in 1983 and began functioning independently in 1984 ([AIMC 2026](#)). It has its roots in women’s participation in India’s independence movement and was established to “empower women and address their specific socio-political issues” and provide a “structured platform for women to engage in the political process, advocate for their rights, and influence policy decisions” ([AIMC 2026](#)). The wing’s website states leadership development as one of its four core aims.

Despite claiming that one of their stated goals is the inclusion of women in the party or women’s leadership development, parties have effectively compartmentalized their members into a separate and unequal institution via the women’s wings. Party leaders themselves recognize this pattern of limited inclusion. A former AIMC President, Sushmita Dev, observed,

“I keep thinking of ways to initiate integration...I suggest the Youth Congress to conduct women empowerment programmes such that we can join them. I tell the parent body that we are hosting a programme and we want our top male leaders to attend it. Sometimes by creating different compartments one tends to isolate women and it becomes that much easy to perpetuate gender discrimination. The idea is to put everybody in one pool and say “now work it out for yourselves.” If somebody has worked in my Frontal Organisation, I make sure that if they have worked diligently they get promoted to the parent body. So, they see the organisation as a stepping stone, a softer platform to get into the mainstream party. Unless we change the perception of women’s organisations, we will just end up being a separate compartment that has nothing to do with the rest of the party” ([Chhibber and Shah 2020](#)).

Dev’s quote highlights both the perils and the promises of women’s wings. In their current iteration, they remain institutions of exclusion; but if integrated into the broader party

organization, they can generate a large group of ambitious women ready for electoral candidacy.

## The Case: Delhi

I situate the study in Delhi, India’s capital, which has an estimated population of 23 million—as large as Switzerland, Finland, Norway, and Denmark combined. It is an urban metropolitan city with multi-party competition at the local and state level. Three main political parties compete for power in Delhi during municipal, state, and national elections: Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), and the Indian National Congress (INC). Since 2015, BJP and AAP have been the dominant players in all three elections, leaving INC without any seats in the state legislature or in the parliament from the state. In February 2025, BJP replaced AAP as the ruling party during the state election. AAP is the main opposition party in the legislature. For this reason, data collected focused on party leaders from only these two parties.<sup>15</sup>

In a broader weakly-institutionalized party system in India ([Jensenius and Suryanarayan 2022](#)), BJP and AAP represent two different types of parties. BJP is best characterized as a right-wing mass-mobilization party, rooted in religious nationalism ([Gunther and Diamond 2003](#)). AAP started off as a movement-based party, born out of an anti-corruption social movement. It is now best understood as a personalistic electoralist party ([Gunther and Diamond 2003](#)), with its political orientation in recent years described as “soft Hindutva” or right-of-center ([Nath 2025](#)). BJP has a thicker and more expansive organization structure and is considered more bureaucratic in its promotion and candidacy practices than AAP. Variation in party age and type allows me to assess how the theory applies to different types of political parties.

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<sup>15</sup>In addition to its diminished political relevance in the state, it was difficult to map the organizational structure and party leaders situated within the INC beyond senior leadership during fieldwork.

# Research Design

## Qualitative Evidence

To ensure the theory, measures in the survey, and reported findings were grounded in empirical realities, I conducted multiple rounds of fieldwork, starting December 2023 until August 2026 in Delhi, India. During this time, I conducted semi-structured in-depth interviews with 106 respondents, recruited through snowball sampling. These included student politicians, party workers and leaders, elected representatives, political strategists and consultants, and non-partisan political activists. Interviewees spanned several political parties and organizations, including the BJP, AAP, INC, Communist Party of India, and All India Trinamool Congress. I also observed the 2025 Delhi state election campaign, which involved attending door-to-door canvassing and press conferences of various parties. Relationships developed with party leaders gave me rare access to a population that is difficult to survey at large. A list of all the individuals interviewed during fieldwork is included in Appendix C.

## Original Survey and Conjoint Experiment

In Delhi, there are approximately 250 ward committees, 70 assembly level committees, 11 district committees, and one state level committee. I surveyed 1,054 post-holding party leaders from BJP and AAP in Delhi, prioritizing breadth across these administrative levels, party wings, and positions.<sup>16</sup> Of these, 554 were from AAP (421 men and 133 women) and 500 were from BJP (297 men and 203 women). Figure 2 shows wards where at least one individual was surveyed. Respondents were surveyed either at their party offices or their homes and each survey lasted approximately 35 minutes.<sup>17</sup> The survey was fielded in-person between August and October 2025.

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<sup>16</sup>Given difficulties of surveying elites at scale, I pool results across elites from different administrative levels. As (Kertzer and Renshon 2022) report, there is little evidence of heterogeneity in results across types of elites, making pooled samples the appropriate method to deal with the small-N problem when surveying elites.

<sup>17</sup>The survey locations are based on the geolocation of the data submitted by enumerators. Respondents' survey locations may not correspond to the ward where they hold a leadership position. Based on the geolocations, however, at least half of Delhi's wards were covered in the survey.

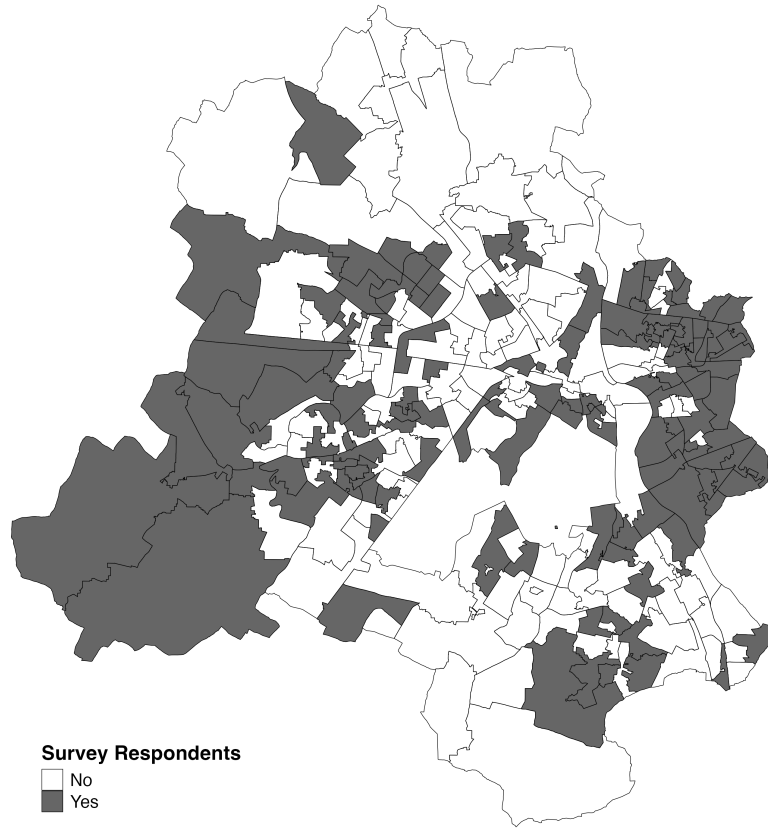


Figure 2: Delhi wards with at least one survey respondent.

Politicians were asked a battery of descriptive questions about their demographic background; political career trajectories, capital, networks, and ambition; and experiences with political violence. To test the mechanisms, the survey included a conjoint experiment that asked party leaders to promote one profile from a hypothetical pair of candidates to either a ward or district President position.

The survey sample is a convenience, snowball-sample; initial names and contacts of party leaders were obtained by establishing relationships with senior party officials during fieldwork.<sup>18</sup> Appendix B shows sample summary statistics as well as sample composition by party, gender, and the current position (administrative level and organization body). 68 percent of the politicians surveyed were men. To begin with, many of the senior

<sup>18</sup>The initial strategy involved a random sample of wards and their corresponding district/assembly-level committees and an attempt to create complete party lists from all selected committees through establishing Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) agreements. This approach, however, ran into many obstacles as top party officials did not want their names on any written agreements. Moreover, many claimed to either not have complete party lists or refused to share them with party outsiders, even with signed agreements of confidentiality.

politicians who agreed to share names of party leaders were men and provided contacts of other men. This is a reflection of the homosocial networks that exist in politics. Surprisingly, more often than not, even women politicians shared contacts of other male politicians. These experiences highlighted that men outnumber women in Indian politics by a significant margin and that women may have been attempting to signal stronger networks and ties (even to researchers) by sharing male colleagues’ contacts.<sup>19</sup> The average age of the politicians in the sample was 46. Slightly over half were from general castes, while the rest were split between Other Backward Castes (OBC) and Scheduled Castes/Scheduled Tribes (SC/ST). The sample is overwhelmingly Hindu, which is to be expected given the parties surveyed. Most respondents were married, half had at least a diploma or Bachelor’s degree, and most were employed and scored high on the asset index.<sup>20</sup> Overall, the sample characteristics reflect that political elites tend to come from more privileged backgrounds and align with demographic backgrounds of local elected politicians surveyed in previous work (Goyal 2024a,2).

## Methods

I report descriptive evidence for several testable implications of the proposed theory. Using OLS regressions with robust standard errors, I present evidence for differences in the networks of entry and promotion patterns between women in the wings and the main party as well as women and men in the wings. For the main tests of the mechanisms, I turn to a combination of causal and descriptive evidence. The primary causal evidence I present involves a forced-choice conjoint experiment administered to all respondents in the sample. The forced-choice conjoint experiment asked each elite respondent to choose one profile from a pair of hypothetical candidates for internal promotion to an organizational leadership role within their party (either the president of the ward committee or the president of a district committee). Each respondent performed the selection

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<sup>19</sup>When asked to share the name, gender, and position of the most important person in their political network, 51 percent of women named another man.

<sup>20</sup>To construct the asset index, I asked respondents to state whether or not they owned/had each of the following assets and took the average: cycle, bike, car, TV, refrigerator, washing machine, computer, an electricity meter, water meter, land, and home.

task four times. Candidate profiles randomly varied across eight ethnographically- and empirically-grounded dimensions: gender, caste, mobilization power, electoral campaign contributions, ability to deliver services to constituents, previous leadership experience in the party, party membership history, and political networks. Appendix E describes the operationalization of each variable and an example vignette.

### Conjoint Estimation Strategy

Following the standard conjoint estimation strategy (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014), I present the Average Marginal Component Effect (AMCE) when reporting the estimates for the binary promotion outcome. For the AMCE, I use the fully non-parametric linear regression estimator presented in Hainmueller et al. (2014), and cluster the standard errors derived from the estimation at the respondent level. In the conjoint, each respondent,  $i$ , was given  $k$  conjoint tasks ( $k \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$ ), and asked to choose their candidate,  $j$  ( $j \in \{1, 2\}$ ), with their preferred characteristics. The resulting OLS regression used to calculate the AMCE is:

$$\begin{aligned} chosen_{ijk} = & \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{gender}_{ijk} = female) + \beta_2(\text{caste}_{ijk} = general) + \\ & \beta_3(\text{financial resources}_{ijk} = low) + \dots + \epsilon_{ijk} \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

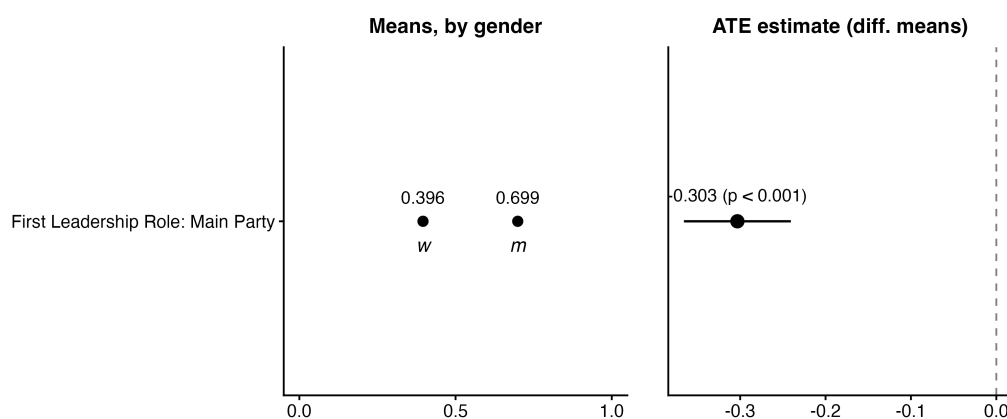
In each task, whether a candidate was chosen is represented by the variable *chosen* which is a binary variable: 1 if the candidate was chosen and 0 if the candidate was not. Because each respondent performed four conjoint tasks, there are eight observations for each respondent (4 for candidates who were chosen and 4 for candidates who were not). For each attribute, the baseline is withheld (for example, for gender the variable  $gender_{ijk} = male$  will be omitted). Each candidate's attribute levels are coded as dummy variables. Therefore, the AMCE for each attribute level must be understood relative to the withheld baseline. When presenting heterogeneous treatment effects (for respondent gender and party and candidate gender), I use Average Marginal Means (AMM) (Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley 2020). I conduct three tests of heterogeneity. I assess the differences in outcomes based on the respondent's gender and party. I also assess heterogeneous

effects based on the hypothetical candidate’s gender, effectively interacting gender with all other attributes. For all three, the appropriate estimand is the AMM, so that results are not sensitive to the withheld baseline (Leeper et al. 2020).

## Results

### Women’s Wings Enable Political Entry

Figure 3: Women’s Party Leadership Careers Less Likely to Begin in Main Party



**Note:** Means of holding a main party leadership role for men (m) and women (w) on the left panel; ATE estimate (Women – Men) with 95% confidence interval on the right panel (p-value in parentheses). Models use robust standard errors.

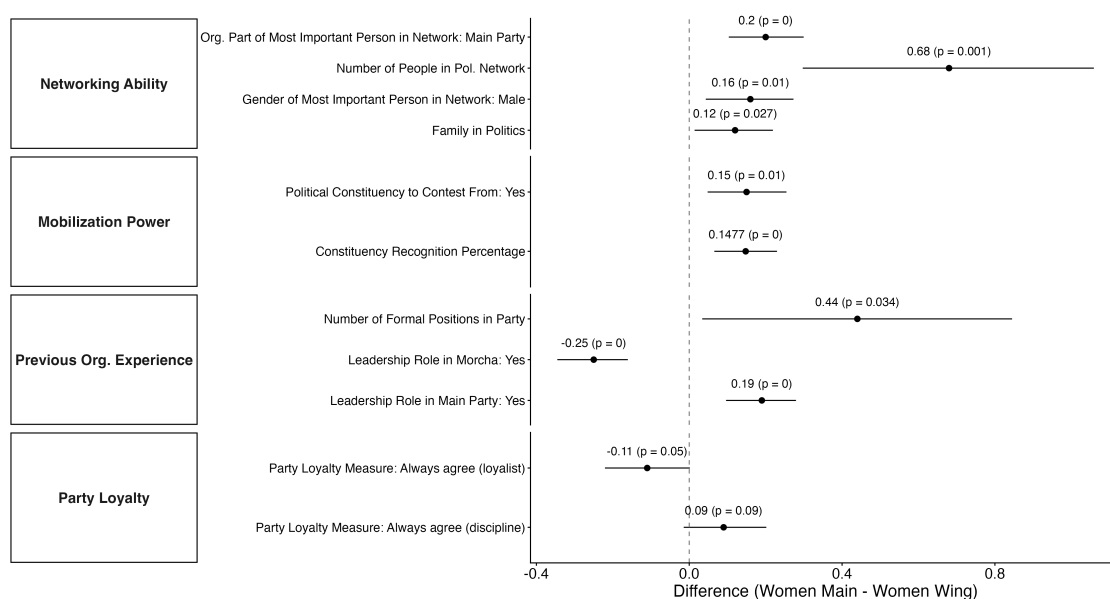
I theorize that women’s wings offer a norm compliant pathway into partisan life to a vast majority of women. To test this empirically, I compare the first party leadership positions held by men and women in my sample. I expect that women’s leadership careers are more likely to begin in the women’s wing, whereas men’s typically begin in the main party organization. I find evidence that supports this: women respondents are 30.3 percentage points (p-value < 0.01) less likely than men to secure their first leadership role within the main party organization (Figure 3). Specifically, while 70 percent of men in the sample receive their first leadership position in the main party organization, only 40 percent of women do. The rest receive leadership positions in the women’s wing. Although this initial leadership role could itself reflect a promotion for a rank-and-file party worker rather than a pathway into the party, this divergence highlights deep gender segregation

within the party structure and institutions where leadership roles are assigned.

## Organizational Division of Labor Sustains Sociopolitical Gaps

Members of the women’s wing occupy specific roles within the party organization that often restrict their opportunities for networking and developing sociopolitical capital. When asked to describe their party contributions (see Appendix H), respondents indicated that women’s wing members on average focused more on community- and service-oriented tasks. This involves engaging with constituents, organizing community events, and managing mobilization or publicity efforts for candidates during election cycles. Conversely, women in the main party organization, on average, handled more administrative and strategic responsibilities. Their work entailed helping voters get voter identification cards, recruiting party members, developing campaign strategies, and overseeing candidate selection. While women’s wing members engage directly with the public, their interactions are often confined to other women within their immediate neighborhoods, thereby narrowing their sphere of influence. By being excluded from the high-level strategic tasks performed by their main party counterparts, these women face significant barriers in accessing party elites, mastering service delivery, and cultivating essential political savvy.

Figure 4: Sociopolitical Gaps between Women’s Wing and Main Party Women



I contend that this division of labor manifests in sociopolitical gaps between women’s wing members and members of the main party organization. Specifically, I compare women whose leadership careers began in the women’s wings to women whose leadership careers began in the main party organization along self-reported networks, mobilization capacity, leadership experience, and party loyalty. Comparing women in the two party institutions (as opposed to women and men) allows me to separate the influence of the institution from gendered differences in sociopolitical capital that may have little to do with the institutions. I find that even after significant tenure within the party, women in the women’s wing possess less sociopolitical capital than women in the main party.

As illustrated in Figure 4, women’s wing members maintain smaller party networks that are largely insulated within the wing; they report fewer connections to male elites and less significant political family ties. Because networks influence functional opportunities within the party, these women gain less organizational leadership experience and hold fewer positions, particularly within the main party organization. Women’s wing members have lower mobilization capacity, despite being tasked with vote mobilization: they are less likely to identify a viable constituency for office or report high levels of public recognition. Additionally, while they demonstrate greater party loyalty—a trait often rewarded in other contexts (Clayton and Zetterberg 2021)—in this instance, it likely facilitates their acquiescence to elite-driven decisions. Notably, these disparities are not driven by class; given the high educational and resource levels across the sample, I find no significant socioeconomic differences between women in the wings and those in the main party (full set of differences reported in Appendix I).

## **Promotion Criteria Overlap With Sociopolitical Capital**

Next, I theorize that there is an overlap between the sociopolitical capital that women’s wing members are unable to develop and the traits elites prioritize during promotion decisions. To isolate the causal impact of candidate characteristics on likelihood of being chosen for promotion, I employed a forced-choice candidate conjoint experiment. Elites were required to select their preferred candidate for a committee presidency at the dis-

trict or ward level. Figure 5 presents the Average Marginal Component Effects (AMCEs), illustrating the specific impact of various candidate attributes on the likelihood of promotion. I corroborated these experimental findings with descriptive survey data, in which respondents identified the most critical traits for male and female leadership within the main party organization (Figure 6).

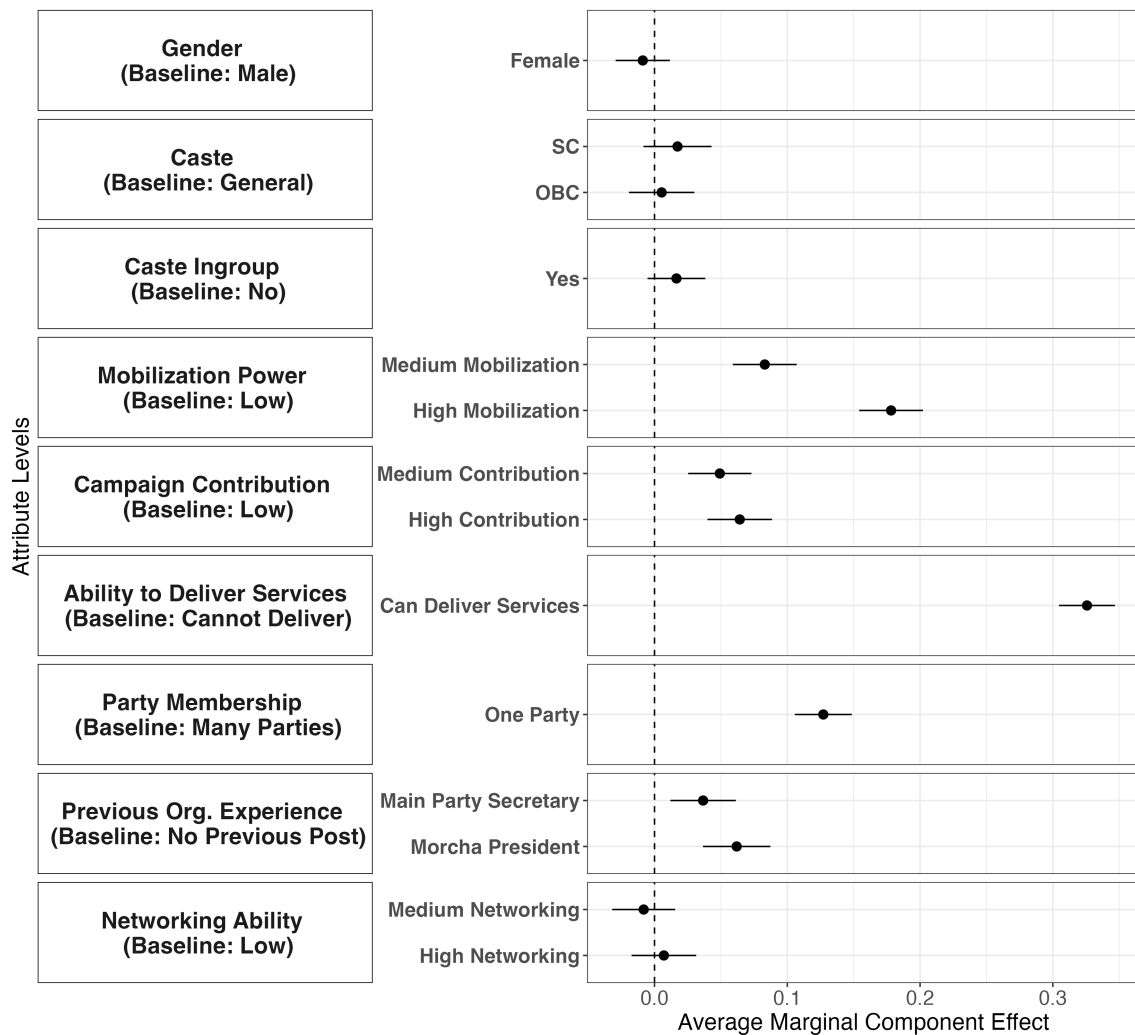


Figure 5: Effect of Attributes on Promotion

I find that service delivery to constituents, mobilization capacity, organizational leadership experience, campaign contributions, and party loyalty play a significant role in determining promotions. Candidates who could organize 250-person rallies were 8.3 percentage points more likely to be promoted ( $p$ -value  $< 0.01$ ), while those who could organize 400-person rallies were 17.8 percentage points more likely to be promoted ( $p$ -value  $< 0.01$ ), both relative to those who could organize 50-person rallies. Candidates who

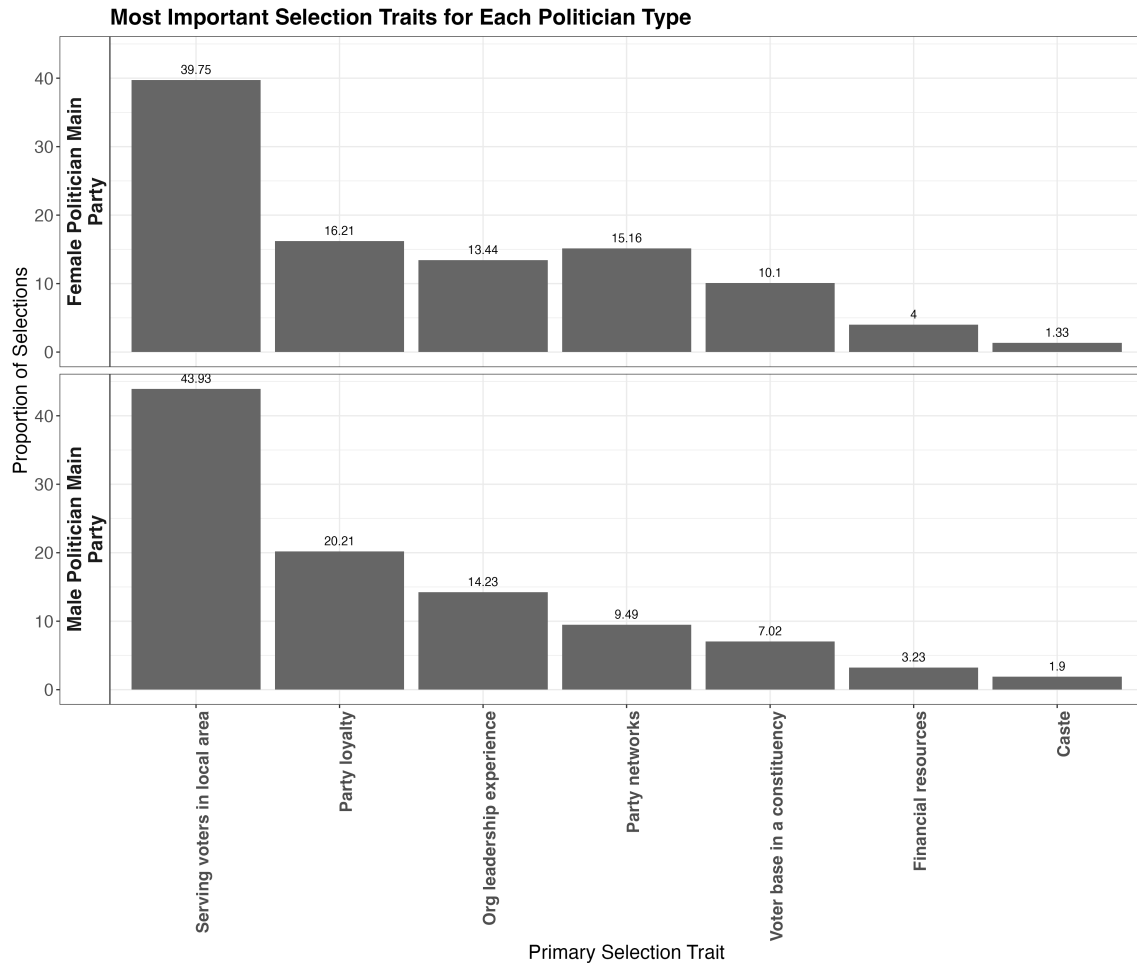


Figure 6: Important Leadership Traits in the Main Party Organization

could contribute Rs. 1-5 lakh to their election campaign were 4.9 percentage points more likely to be promoted ( $p\text{-value} < 0.01$ ), while those who could contribute Rs. 5-10 lakh were 6.4 percentage points more likely to be promoted ( $p\text{-value} < 0.01$ ), both relative to those who could contribute less than 1 lakh. Most significantly, candidates who could get constituents' problems fixed were 32.5 percentage points more likely to be promoted ( $p\text{-value} < 0.01$ ), relative to someone who could not get problems fixed. Party loyalty also mattered, as candidates who were lifelong members of the same party were 12.7 percentage points more likely to be promoted ( $p\text{-value} < 0.01$ ), relative to a candidate who had been part of multiple parties. Lastly, holding posts in the organization mattered for promotion; candidates who had previously been the secretary in the main party organization were 3.6 percentage points more likely to be promoted ( $p\text{-value} = 0.003$ ), while candidates who had been party wing presidents were 6.1 percentage points more likely to

be promoted (p-value < 0.01), both relative to a candidate who had never held a post.

Though stronger networks are not predictive of promotion in the conjoint experiment,<sup>21</sup> certain predictive attributes—organizational leadership roles held, recognition in a constituency resulting in mobilization power, and administrative networks that enable service delivery—are consequent benefits of having the right political networks during one’s political career. Moreover, descriptive data in Figure 6 indicates that having the right party networks is an important selection trait, particularly for women in the main party organization.

## Lower Organizational Mobility for Women’s Wing Members

In this paper, I argue that women’s wing members experience lower organizational mobility along three dimensions: lateral promotions into the main party organization, upward promotions in rank and administrative level in the women’s wing, and electoral candidacy. Empirically, I benchmark women’s wing members against men in party wings for lateral promotion, and against women in the main party organization for upward promotion and electoral candidacy.

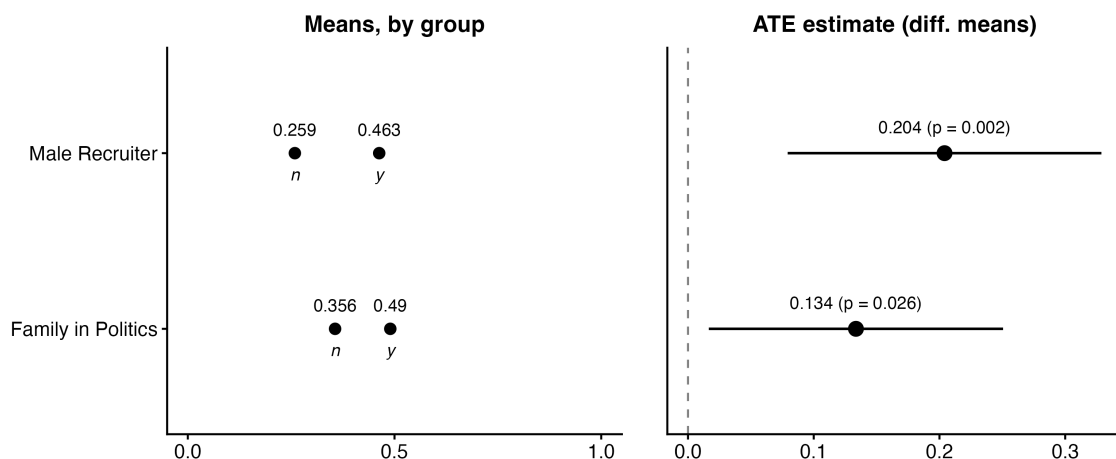
I also address concerns around self-selection. Women’s wing members may differ from women in the main party organization at baseline, and the same factors that sort women into the wing could depress their promotion and candidacy rates. Elite networks and family connections prior to entry, in particular, likely shape whether a woman joins through the main party organization or the women’s wing. Indeed, women from political dynasties account for a disproportionate share of female candidates and elected representatives in India (ADR 2025; Basu 2016). Yet if recruitment and entry were the primary barriers to women’s representation, those barriers should ease once women are inside a party. I show that they do not. Rather than offsetting selection effects and leveling the playing field, women’s wings amplify the pre-existing differences between elite and non-elite women. I establish this in two steps. First, I show that women’s elite networks prior to entry predict higher rates of attaining a first leadership position in the main party organiza-

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<sup>21</sup>It is also plausible that respondents were not sensitive to differences in networks in the particular operationalization used in the conjoint.

tion. Second, I report both raw difference-in-means and OLS-adjusted estimates of the promotion outcomes, where the adjusted models control for pre-entry elite networks and years in office.

Figure 7: The Selection Penalty: Women’s Elite Networks and First Leadership Role

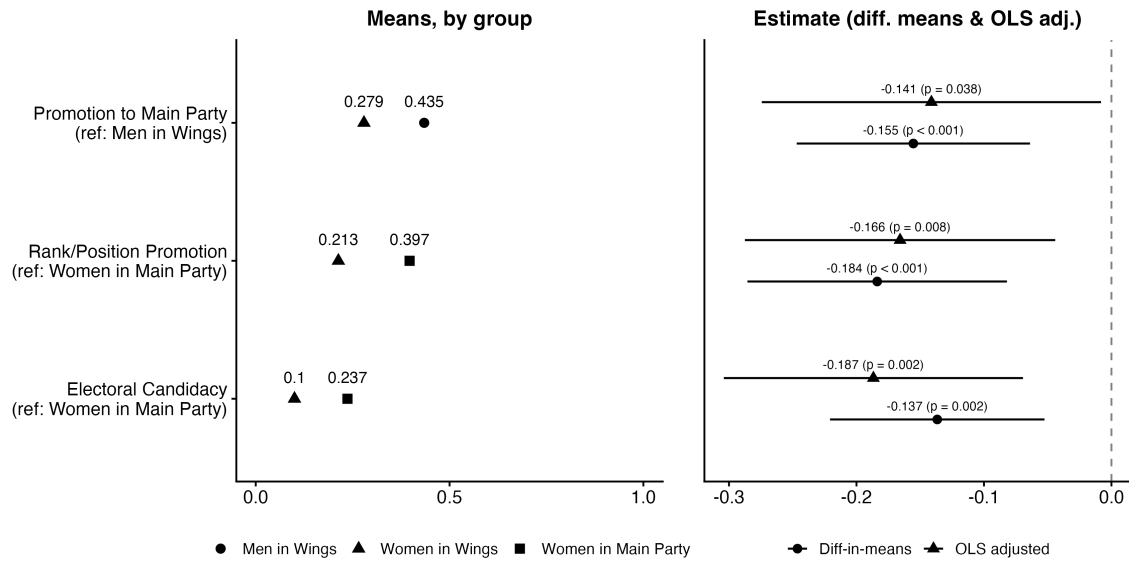


**Note:** Outcome is whether a woman’s first leadership role was in the main party (vs. a wing), among women respondents. Left panel shows group means, where ‘y’ and ‘n’ indicate whether the woman had a male recruiter (top row) and family in politics (bottom row) or not. Right panel shows the ATE (difference in means) with 95% confidence intervals (p-values in parentheses). Robust standard errors.

To assess whether women selected into the women’s wing and main party organization based on their preexisting networks, I use two measures. The survey asked respondents, “Who encouraged you to join politics?” with options for male or female family member, friend, and party worker or leader. Respondents were also asked whether they had family in politics. Figure 7 compares women with networks to those without. I find that women encouraged by a male family member, friend, or party worker were 20.4 percentage points (p-value < 0.01) more likely to begin their leadership career in the main party organization, relative to women encouraged by a female family member, friend, or party worker. Women with family in politics were also 13.4 percentage points (p-value = 0.025) more likely to begin their leadership career in the main party organization, relative to those without.

Controlling for these elite networks prior to entry as well as years in the party, I find that women’s wings still impose a penalty on their members’ promotion outcomes (right panel of Figure 8). Women whose leadership careers begin in the women’s wing are

Figure 8: The Women's Wing Penalty in Promotion Outcomes



**Note:** Left panel shows group means by outcome (first leadership position): MW = men in wings, WW = women in women's wings, WM = women in the main party. Right panel shows estimates with 95% confidence intervals (p-values in parentheses): circles are difference-in-means, triangles are OLS estimates adjusting for recruiter gender, family in politics, and years in party. Promotion to Main Party compares men vs. women in the wings; Rank/Position Promotion and Electoral Candidacy compare women in the wings vs. women in the main party. All models use robust standard errors.

14.1 percentage points (p-value = 0.038) less likely to be promoted into the main party organization, relative to men whose careers begin in party wings. Compared to women in the main party organization, women in the women's wing are 16.6 percentage points (p-value < 0.01) less likely to be promoted in administrative rank or position. Lack of promotion to formal party positions has enduring negative consequences for electoral candidacy. Women in the women's wing are 18.7 percentage points (p-value < 0.01) less likely to become candidates, relative to women in the main party organization. This demonstrates that even though networks sort women into distinct institutions, being in the women's wing itself exacerbates barriers to their political advancement.

## Women's Wing Members are Highly Ambitious

Lack of political ambition is an oft-positied barrier to women's political entry (Fox and Lawless 2003,0,1; Lawless 2012; Lawless and Fox 2010). By this logic, women's wing members may simply not wish to advance into the main party organization or run as

candidates, whether because they face resistance from family members wary of a male-dominated space, anticipate pushback from party elites reluctant to promote them, or are content with their positions in the women’s wing. Both ground-level realities and the empirical evidence, however, overwhelmingly reject lack of political ambition as a source of their stymied organizational mobility, as I show below.

Figure 9: Political Ambition Among Survey Respondents

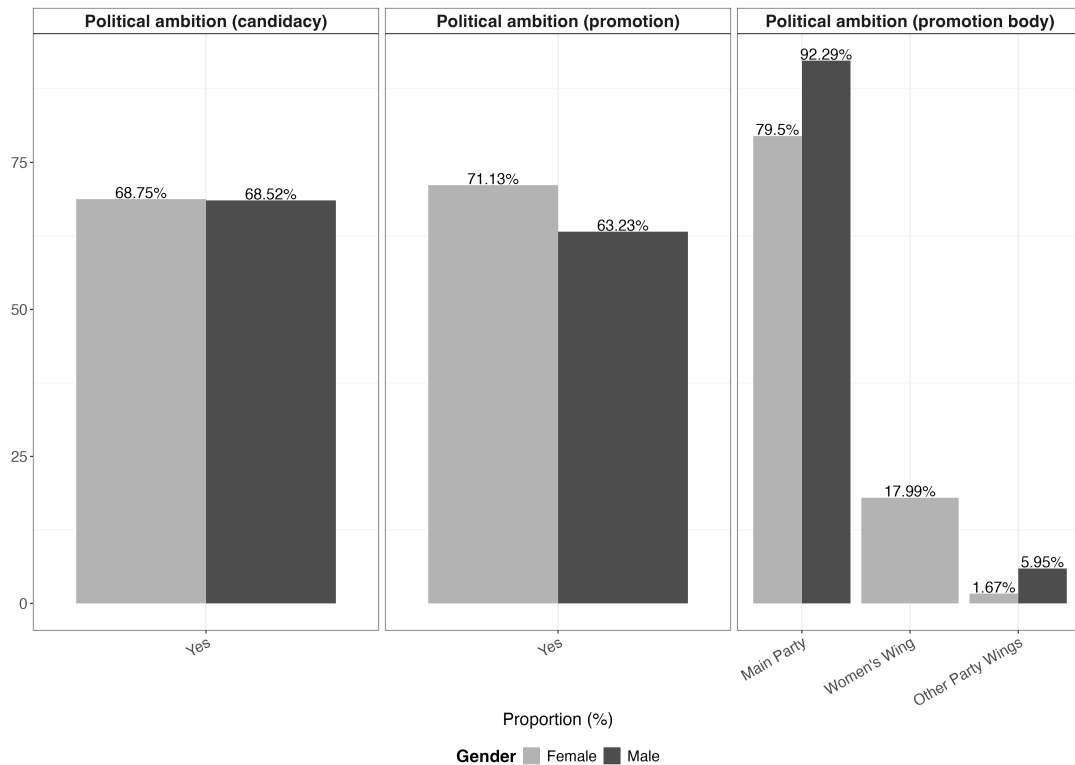


Figure 9 shows equal or higher rates of political ambition for electoral candidacy and promotion among male and female respondents in the survey sample. Among politically ambitious women, nearly 80 percent express ambition to be promoted into the main party organization as opposed to any other party wing. Disaggregated by where their partisan leadership careers began, 62.5 percent of women’s wing members expressed ambition for candidacy (relative to 77 percent of main party women) and 67.5 percent for promotions in party leadership (relative to 78 percent of main party women). Of these politically ambitious women, 74 percent hoped for promotions into the main party organization (relative to 88 percent of politically ambitious main party women).

## Discussion

Women’s wings are institutions of unfulfilled promise. They remain the primary pathway for women to join political parties in contexts with patriarchal and gendered social norms and have been shown to increase women’s political inclusion and in some cases, even upward political mobility (Goyal 2024a,2). In the absence of women’s wings, it is likely that women’s political inclusion in parties would decrease substantially and be limited to those with connections to male party elites and representatives. At the same time, because party organizations use women’s wings mainly to mobilize women voters, members of these wings are deprived of opportunities to develop the essential networks and sociopolitical capital that makes them desirable for intra-party promotions. Thus, women’s wings become a parallel and unequal career track for women within political parties. A glass wall separates their members from the main party organization. This pattern is similar to portfolio segregation that women politicians experience in assignments to cabinets and ministries (Curtin et al. 2023; Krook and O’Brien 2012).

The glass wall is a uniquely gendered barrier; it is far less likely to affect men whose leadership careers begin in party wings, such as student, youth, and caste wings. At baseline, a smaller proportion of men become leaders in party wings compared to a majority of women who do become leaders in women’s wings. Moreover, wings act as stepping stones for men in their political careers. They allow men to accumulate the networks and sociopolitical capital necessary for advancing in the party hierarchy. But even when they do not, male elites overtly discriminate against women and prefer to promote men over equally qualified women.<sup>22</sup>

As with quotas, this paper shows that institutions designed to increase women’s political participation and representation may instead reaffirm inequalities. They may be co-opted by male elites, as is the case of women elected via quotas (Amar et al. 2025; Heinze et al. 2025), or engineered to provide limited inclusion, as is the case with women’s wings. In other words, women’s wings act as a form of institutional discrimination since

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<sup>22</sup>In Appendix J, I show the gender bias present among male party elites and benchmark it against the lack of in-group caste bias.

their role within the party organization deliberately prevents women from gaining the experience and capital necessary for political advancement. It allows parties to present as gender-inclusive and use women party workers to advance their agenda and mobilize women voters without providing meaningful power and authority to their own women members. So, what are the normative implications of these findings? I do not advocate for removing women’s wings from political parties. Rather, I suggest that fully integrating women’s wings and their members into the party is a way out. By identifying a glass wall separating the women’s wing and the main party, sustained by the second-tier status of the wing, this paper underscores the actors and processes central to advancing women’s representation. In addition to mobilizing women’s votes and advocating for women’s issues, women’s wing members should be integrated into essential decision-making within the main party organization. This includes involving its members in campaign planning and candidate selection during elections; including them on teams of all elected representatives, regardless of gender; inviting them into the process of delivering services to constituents; and creating gender-sensitive governance structures within the party. It also includes promoting substantial shares of women from the women’s wing to the main party organization—treating entry into politics via the women’s wing as a stepping stone (as other party wings are), rather than a silo. Fixing the pipeline within parties—breaking the glass wall to advance women upward in the hierarchy—is a necessary step to producing viable women electoral candidates.

Although the theory is drawn from India, it extends to contexts beyond the case and parties presented in the paper. Political parties are central to political life across the globe and women’s wings are found in nearly 40 percent of parties ([Scarrow et al. 2022](#)). Political networks are consequential for women’s political success in several low-information and patriarchal environments across the Global South ([Arriola, Phillips, and Rakner 2021](#); [Phillips 2021](#); [Wang and Muriaas 2019](#)). Elite gatekeeping is a feature of partisan life across many political contexts, from Asia to Europe to Africa. The patterns of career mobility, elite bias, and gendered promotion criteria are fairly consistent across both parties surveyed (Appendices [G.1](#), [M](#), and [N](#)), though differences are moderately

stronger among BJP respondents. This suggests that while the results likely apply to a variety of party types, generalized inferences require a nuanced understanding of internal party dynamics across different party types.

This paper sets up several avenues for future research. First, scholars should examine interventions that can dismantle the glass wall, such as mentorship programs connecting wing leaders with main party elites to improve promotion rates. Second, a systematic comparative analysis of women’s wings across electoral systems, countries, and party types may help us identify conditions that enable women’s wings to be effective institutions. Finally, comparing promotion outcomes in other types of wings—particularly youth and student wings—to women’s wings would provide additional insight into whether the “glass wall” phenomenon applies to sub-organizations writ large or is specific to gendered institutions. Answering these questions will be critical for designing inclusionary institutions that effectively translate women’s participation into meaningful inclusion.

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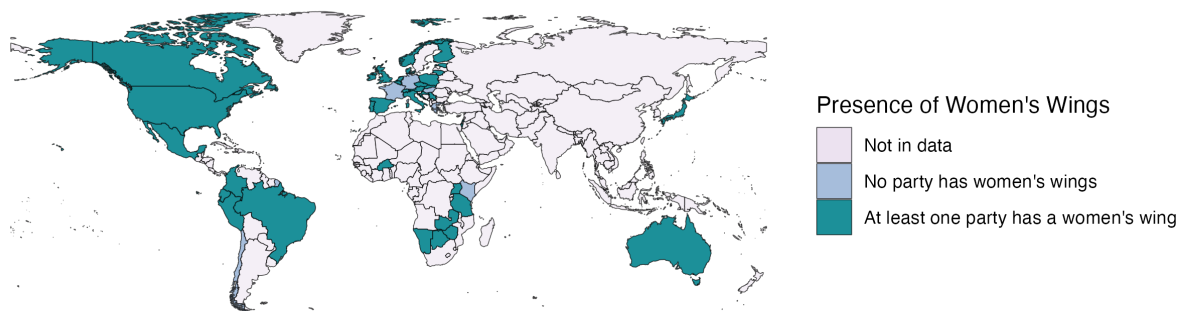
Appendix for  
“Are Women’s Wings Barriers to Women’s Political Advancement?”

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## A Women's Wings in Political Parties

Countries with Women's Wings in Parties



Source: Political Party Database (Poguntke et al. 2022).

Figure SI.1: Distribution of Women's Wings in Parties

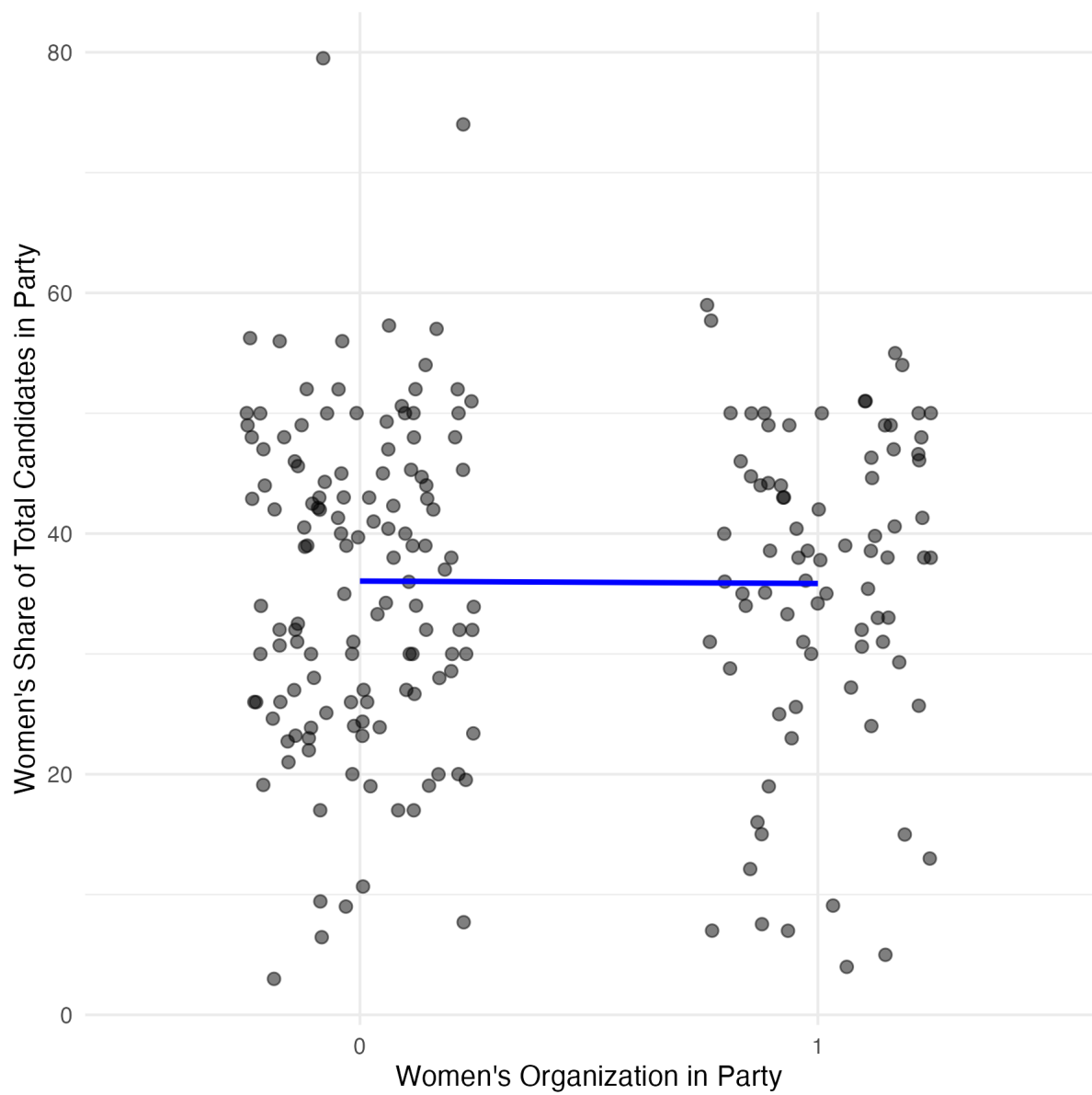


Figure SI.2: Correlation Between Women's Wing in Party and Share of Women Candidates in Party

## B Sample Composition

Table SI.1: Summary Statistics of Survey Sample

| Variable                 | N    | Pct./Mean | Std. Dev. |
|--------------------------|------|-----------|-----------|
| <b>Gender</b>            | 1054 |           |           |
| Female                   | 336  | 32 %      |           |
| Male                     | 718  | 68 %      |           |
| <b>Age</b>               | 1054 | 47        | 11        |
| <b>Caste</b>             | 1032 |           |           |
| General                  | 552  | 53 %      |           |
| OBC                      | 252  | 24 %      |           |
| SC/ST                    | 228  | 22 %      |           |
| <b>Religion</b>          | 1054 |           |           |
| Hindu                    | 956  | 91 %      |           |
| Muslim                   | 67   | 6 %       |           |
| Other                    | 31   | 3 %       |           |
| <b>Marital Status</b>    | 1054 |           |           |
| Married                  | 949  | 90 %      |           |
| Not Married              | 105  | 10 %      |           |
| <b>Education Status</b>  | 1054 |           |           |
| 10th pass and below      | 216  | 20 %      |           |
| 12th pass                | 305  | 29 %      |           |
| BA/diploma and higher    | 533  | 51 %      |           |
| <b>Employment Status</b> | 1054 |           |           |
| Employed                 | 841  | 80 %      |           |
| Homemaker                | 141  | 13 %      |           |
| Not Employed             | 72   | 7 %       |           |
| <b>Asset Index</b>       | 1054 | 0.83      | 0.15      |
| <b>Political Party</b>   | 1054 |           |           |
| AAP                      | 554  | 53 %      |           |
| BJP                      | 500  | 47 %      |           |

*Notes:* For categorical variables, the third column reports the percentage of the sample in each category; for continuous variables (Age, Asset Index), it reports the mean with the standard deviation. The Asset Index is the share of 11 household assets a respondent owns (range 0–1).

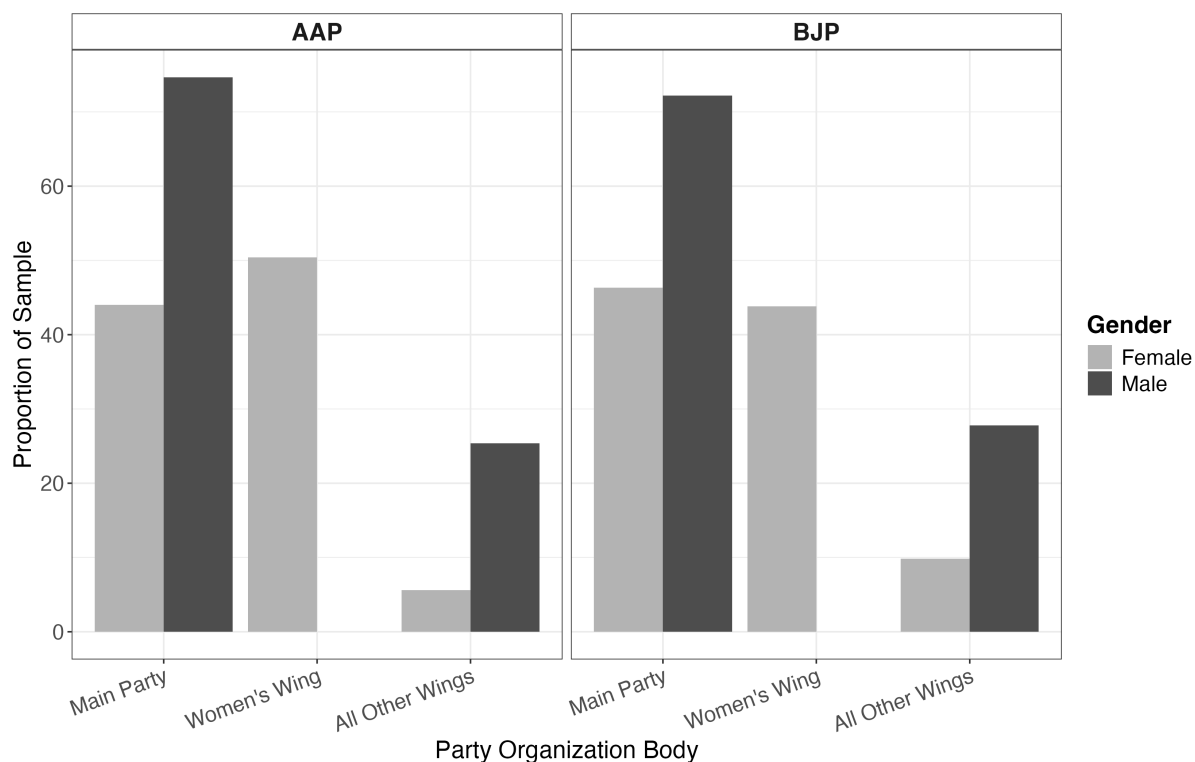


Figure SI.3: Survey Sample by Party, Gender, and Organization Part

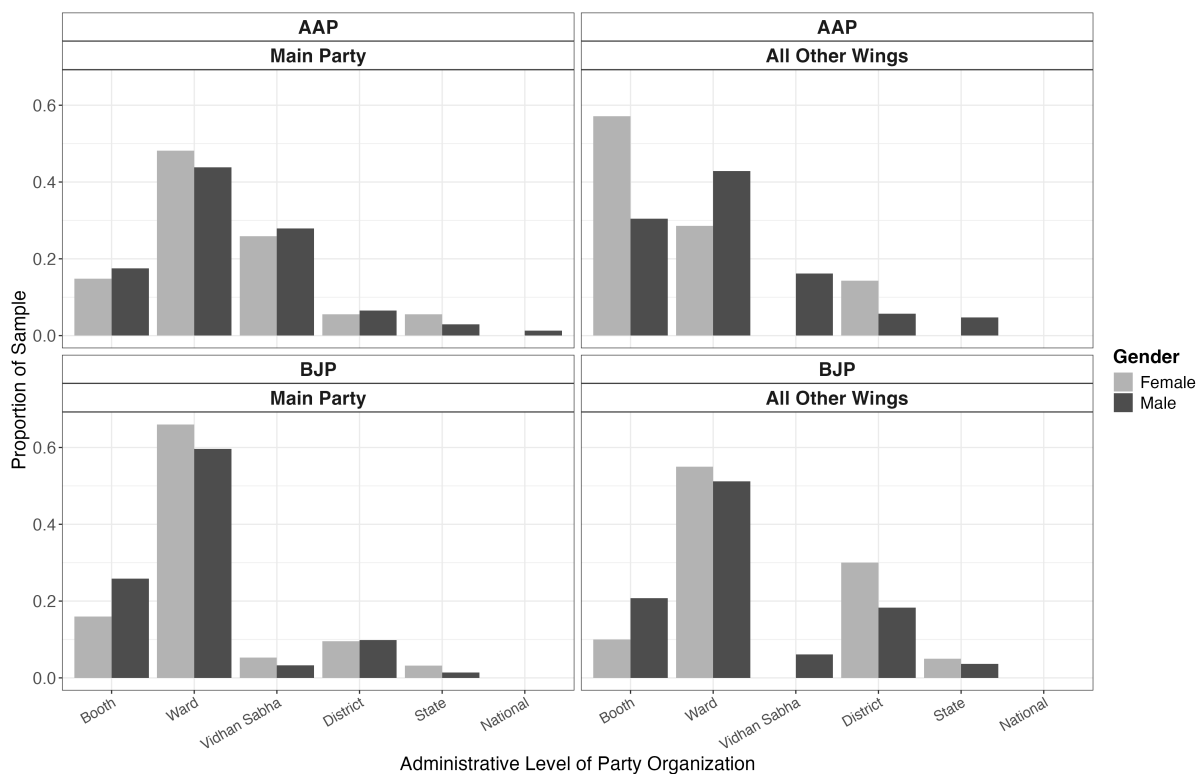


Figure SI.4: Sample Composition by Party, Gender, Administrative Levels, and Wings

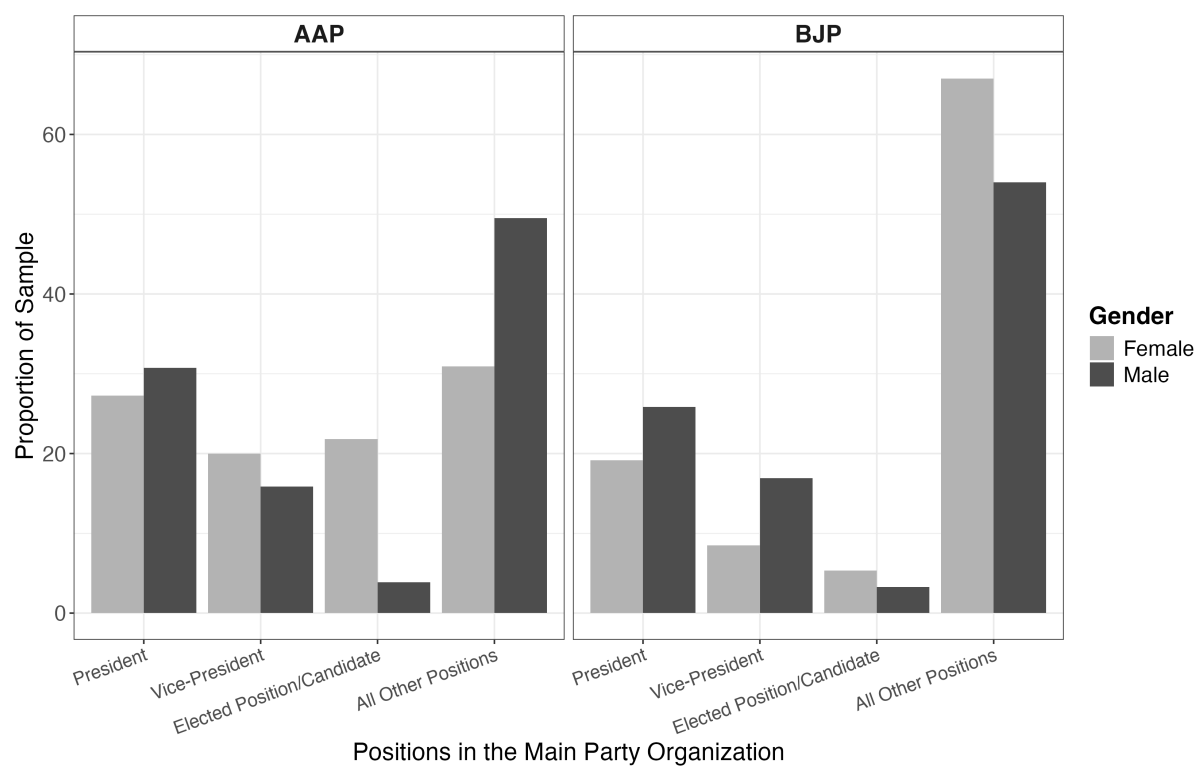


Figure SI.5: Sample Composition by Positions in the Main Party Organization and Gender

## C Interview List

Table SI.2: Designations of Interviewees

| Role / Designation                                        | Date              |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Activist                                                  | December 26, 2023 |
| Activist, non-profit                                      | January 4, 2024   |
| Activist, social movement leader                          | January 8, 2024   |
| Activist, professor                                       | January 9, 2024   |
| Activist, politician                                      | January 9, 2024   |
| IAS officer, non-profit head                              | January 11, 2024  |
| Political consultant, activist                            | January 12, 2024  |
| Non-profit head                                           | January 30, 2024  |
| Residents' Welfare Association leader, retired professor  | July 21, 2024     |
| Former DU Teacher's Association leader, retired professor | July 23, 2024     |
| Residents' Welfare Association leader, entrepreneur       | July 23, 2024     |
| Political party spokesperson                              | July 27, 2024     |
| Political party youth wing leader                         | July 29, 2024     |
| Activist, retired professor                               | July 30, 2024     |
| Former political strategist, activist                     | July 31, 2024     |
| Current Member of Legislative Assembly                    | August 1, 2024    |
| Political strategist                                      | August 3, 2024    |
| Political strategist                                      | August 4, 2024    |
| Political party women's wing leader                       | August 5, 2024    |
| Political party worker, non-profit head                   | August 5, 2024    |
| Ex-Member of Legislative Assembly, political party worker | August 5, 2024    |
| Lok Sabha political communications strategist             | August 7, 2024    |
| Political party spokesperson                              | August 13, 2024   |
| Party worker/leader                                       | August 13, 2024   |
| Delhi University student politician                       | August 21, 2024   |

Table SI.2: Designations of Interviewees

| Role / Designation                                             | Date             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Delhi University student politician                            | August 21, 2024  |
| Political party state leadership                               | August 26, 2024  |
| Current Rajya Sabha Member of Parliament                       | August 29, 2024  |
| Activist, Ex-Student Politics, Ex-Political party worker       | August 30, 2024  |
| Media campaign strategist for political party                  | August 26, 2024  |
| Ex-LAMP fellow, researcher                                     | December 5, 2024 |
| Ex-LAMP fellow, Member of Parliament office                    | December 8, 2024 |
| Ex-LAMP fellow, Member of Parliament office                    | January 3, 2025  |
| AAP Women's Wing In-Charge                                     | January 7, 2025  |
| Delhi University student                                       | January 9, 2025  |
| Delhi University student                                       | January 9, 2025  |
| Lok Sabha Member of Parliament                                 | January 14, 2025 |
| Political consultant, strategist                               | January 16, 2025 |
| Political consultant, strategist                               | January 16, 2025 |
| Political consultant                                           | January 20, 2025 |
| Political fellowship team                                      | January 21, 2025 |
| Party worker/leader                                            | January 22, 2025 |
| Party worker, former Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor | January 22, 2025 |
| Party worker/leader                                            | January 22, 2025 |
| Party worker/leader                                            | January 23, 2025 |
| Party worker/leader                                            | January 23, 2025 |
| Party worker/leader                                            | January 23, 2025 |
| Party worker                                                   | January 23, 2025 |
| Party worker                                                   | January 23, 2025 |
| Former political consultant                                    | January 30, 2025 |
| Political consultant                                           | February 7, 2025 |
| Political consultant                                           | February 7, 2025 |

Table SI.2: Designations of Interviewees

| Role / Designation                                      | Date              |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|
| Party worker/leader                                     | November 15, 2025 |
| Party worker/leader                                     | January 23, 2026  |
| Party worker/leader                                     | January 26, 2026  |
| Party worker/leader                                     | January 26, 2026  |
| Student politician                                      | July 22, 2026     |
| Student politician                                      | July 22, 2026     |
| Student politician                                      | July 22, 2026     |
| Student politician                                      | July 22, 2026     |
| Student politician                                      | July 23, 2026     |
| Student politician                                      | July 23, 2026     |
| Student politician                                      | July 23, 2026     |
| Party leader, former student politician                 | July 23, 2026     |
| Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor, party leader | July 24, 2026     |
| Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor               | July 27, 2026     |
| Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor               | July 27, 2026     |
| Party worker/leader                                     | July 29, 2026     |
| Party worker/leader                                     | July 29, 2026     |
| Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor               | July 29, 2026     |
| Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor               | July 29, 2026     |
| Party leader, student politician                        | July 29, 2026     |
| Student politician                                      | July 29, 2026     |
| Former party leader                                     | July 30, 2026     |
| Party worker                                            | July 30, 2026     |
| Former party leader                                     | July 31, 2026     |
| Party worker                                            | August 3, 2026    |
| Party worker                                            | August 3, 2026    |
| Party leader                                            | August 3, 2026    |

Table SI.2: Designations of Interviewees

| Role / Designation                        | Date            |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Former party leader                       | August 3, 2026  |
| Former party leader                       | August 3, 2026  |
| Former party leader                       | August 3, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 4, 2026  |
| Party leader                              | August 4, 2026  |
| Party leader                              | August 4, 2026  |
| Party leader                              | August 4, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 5, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 5, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 5, 2026  |
| Party leader                              | August 5, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 6, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 6, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 6, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 6, 2026  |
| Party worker, former student politician   | August 6, 2026  |
| Municipal Corporation of Delhi councillor | August 6, 2026  |
| Party leader                              | August 6, 2026  |
| Party leader                              | August 6, 2026  |
| Party leader                              | August 6, 2026  |
| Party leader                              | August 6, 2026  |
| Party worker                              | August 10, 2026 |
| Party leader                              | August 10, 2026 |
| Party leader                              | August 10, 2026 |
| Party leader                              | August 10, 2026 |
| Party worker                              | August 11, 2026 |
| Party leader                              | August 11, 2026 |

## D Organizational Roles

Table SI.3: List of Organizational Roles

| No. | Role/Position                                                |
|-----|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0   | Election Candidate/Representative                            |
| 1   | President                                                    |
| 2   | Vice-President                                               |
| 3   | In-Charge/Prabhari                                           |
| 4   | General Secretary                                            |
| 5   | General Secretary (Organization)                             |
| 6   | Secretary                                                    |
| 7   | Treasurer                                                    |
| 8   | IT and/or Social Media In-Charge                             |
| 9   | Office Secretary/Co Office Secretary                         |
| 10  | Spokesperson                                                 |
| 11  | Chief Spokesperson                                           |
| 12  | Media In-Charge/Co In-Charge                                 |
| 13  | Election In-Charge/Co In-Charge                              |
| 14  | Executive Member                                             |
| 15  | Organisational Secretary                                     |
| 16  | Ground-Level Workers (e.g. Panna Pramukh, Kamal Sakhi, etc.) |

## E Conjoint Experiment Vignette

Table SI.4 shows all the attributes and their levels presented in the conjoint. The survey had three types of randomization: (1) Order of the attributes was randomized, (2) The level of the attribute presented was randomized, and (3) The committee for which the leader was being selected was randomized between ward- and district-level. All attributes were weighted equally. The conjoint was placed after a set of demographic questions to prevent any post-treatment bias in the heterogeneous effects analysis.

| Factor                              | Operationalization              | Levels                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gender                              | Gender                          | Male (baseline)<br>Female                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Caste                               | Caste                           | General (baseline)<br>SC<br>OBC                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Ability to establish electoral base | Mobilization power              | Organized a 50 person rally in their locality (baseline)<br>Organized a 250 person rally in their locality<br>Organized a 400 person rally in their locality                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| Financial resources                 | Electoral campaign contribution | Less than 1 lakh (baseline)<br><br>Between Rs. 1 lakh and Rs. 5 lakh<br>Between Rs. 5 lakh and Rs. 10 lakh                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Delivering Constituency Services    | Ability to get work done        | This candidate got ( <i>did not get (baseline)</i> ) the municipality to fix a broken road after residents complained<br>This candidate got ( <i>did not get (baseline)</i> ) the municipality to collect trash after residents complained<br>This candidate got ( <i>did not get (baseline)</i> ) the municipality to install streetlights after residents complained |
| Party loyalty                       | Party membership                | Been a member of multiple parties (baseline)<br>Been a lifelong member of your party                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Party leadership experience         | Highest post in the party       | No post held previously (baseline)<br><br>[Mandal/District] committee secretary<br>[Mandal/District]-level Morcha President (such as Mahila Morcha, Yuva Morcha, etc.)                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Party Networks                      | Networking ability              | Got the current mandal president to speak at a rally (baseline)<br>Got the current MLA to speak at a rally<br>Got the current state unit president to speak at a rally                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

Table SI.4: Attributes for Candidate Profiles

The vignette was prefaced with the following introduction:

“Political parties often make decisions about which party members to promote to party leadership roles, such as ward president, election in-charge, morcha secretary etc. When doing so, parties consider many different attributes about a party member that would make them a suitable leader. I will now present to you hypothetical profiles of two candidates that your party is considering promoting to the role of a [mandal/district]-committee president. The attributes of these candidates will be randomly chosen. Your task will be to choose the most suitable candidate for promotion and for appointing to different roles in the party. We will repeat this task four times. I will first read the profiles of each candidate out loud one by one. If you would like, you can then look over the profiles yourself. Then I will ask you to choose your preferred candidate.”

The vignette was then presented in a tabular form. Respondents were read the profiles out loud first and then if they asked, were handed the tablet to review the profiles.

Below I describe the theoretical basis for operationalization of each variable.

## **Gender and Caste**

To assess gender bias against women politicians, I varied the gender of the prospective candidate between male and female. Given the salience of caste in Indian politics, I tested the effects of the candidate’s caste on the likelihood of being chosen for promotion. The caste varied between general, Scheduled Castes (SC), and Other Backward Castes (OBC). I did not include Scheduled Tribes as a category, since they are not politically salient in Delhi. Along with a measure of caste, I created a post-hoc measure matching the hypothetical candidate’s caste to the respondent’s caste using the demographic data collected in the survey. This allowed me to test ethnic in-group selection effects.

## **Mobilization Power**

Vote mobilizers are critical during electoral cycles ([Chhibber and Ostermann 2014](#); [Goyal 2024b](#)). Recent work has shown the importance of mobilization capacity of brokers in clientelistic settings ([Auerbach and Thachil 2023](#)). I assessed the effect of mobilization power on being selected for promotion. I varied the number of individuals the hypothetical candidate was able to draw out for a rally in their neighborhood. A 50-person

rally indicated low mobilization capacity, 250-person rally indicated medium mobilization capacity, and 400-person rally indicated high mobilization capacity.

## **Electoral Campaign Contribution**

Indian elections are the most expensive in the world and money plays a ubiquitous role in Indian politics (Bussell 2018; Vaishnav 2017). During the 2024 national election, Indian parties were estimated to have spent approximately \$14.4 billion (Pradhan 2024). BJP's reported expenditure to the Election Commission of India during the 2025 Delhi state election was \$6.3 million (Paliwal 2025). This included a payout of nearly \$28,000 to each candidate. By a different estimate, candidates themselves funded 11 percent of their total expenses during the election (Kumar 2025). These are all likely underestimating the actual expenditure during elections. It is difficult to trace informal and unofficial campaign expenses, including illegal payments made to constituents in exchange for votes (Pradhan 2024). An individual's financial resources matter even before electoral campaigning, with widespread 'ticket-buying' during the nomination phase (Singh 2023). In this context, being able to demonstrate the ability to contribute financially to one's own electoral campaign can signal both leadership and candidate viability to the party. I varied the hypothetical candidate's contributions to an election across less than Rs. 1 lakh (low contribution), between Rs. 1 lakh and 5 lakh (medium contribution), and between Rs. 5 lakh and 10 lakh (high contribution). Given that the leadership positions posed in the vignette were at the local level, these amounts are contextually appropriate.

## **Ability to Deliver Services**

In clientelistic settings, getting work done for constituents is critical for politicians. A senior party leader and elected politician indicated that voters care most about how their lives will improve; when they decide what party to vote for, they consider whether they will get electricity, water, and better roads.<sup>1</sup> Successful claim-making and service delivery on behalf of constituents makes a politician more valuable to the party since

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<sup>1</sup>Interview Subject 16, interviewed by author on August 1, 2024, in New Delhi, India.

she can garner more votes and more supporters in a constituency ([Auerbach and Thachil 2023](#); [Auerbach et al. 2025](#)). To test how effective service delivery impacts a candidate's viability for promotion, I used a measure drawn from [Auerbach et al. \(2025\)](#). I created a binary variable that combined all positive instances of service delivery (getting a broken road fixed, trash collected, and streetlight installed) and all negative instances of service delivery (not getting a broken road fixed, trash collected, and streetlight installed). Doing so allowed me to test the impact of successful service delivery without it being sensitive to a particular service being delivered.

## **Party Membership History**

Fieldwork revealed the central role of party loyalty, defined by politicians as both the time spent in a single party and the number of parties one has been a part of. In the experiment, I operationalized party loyalty in terms of the latter. The hypothetical candidate could have either been a part of multiple parties during their career or a lifelong member of the respondent's party.

## **Previous Roles in Party Organization**

Politicians in the field repeatedly emphasized that entering the party at the grassroots level and rising up the hierarchy were both possible (democratizing party membership) and necessary to be considered for promotion and candidacy. To test whether a hypothetical candidate's previous party organization leadership experience influenced their selection, I varied the highest post she had held in the party. The candidate could either be a first-time leader (no post previously held), a committee secretary, or a committee wing president.

## **Networking Ability**

Lastly, I assessed whether an individual's networks influenced their likelihood of selection as a party leader. As discussed in the theory section, networks are not only central to political entry, but also to advancement post-entry. To test this, I varied the post of

the politician invited by the hypothetical candidate to a party rally. The post of the ‘guest of honor’ or the main guest at a rally can signal the quality of an individual’s political network. A ward-level president indicated low networking ability, an elected state legislator indicated medium ability, and a state-committee president indicated high ability.

## F Differences in Political Entry Networks

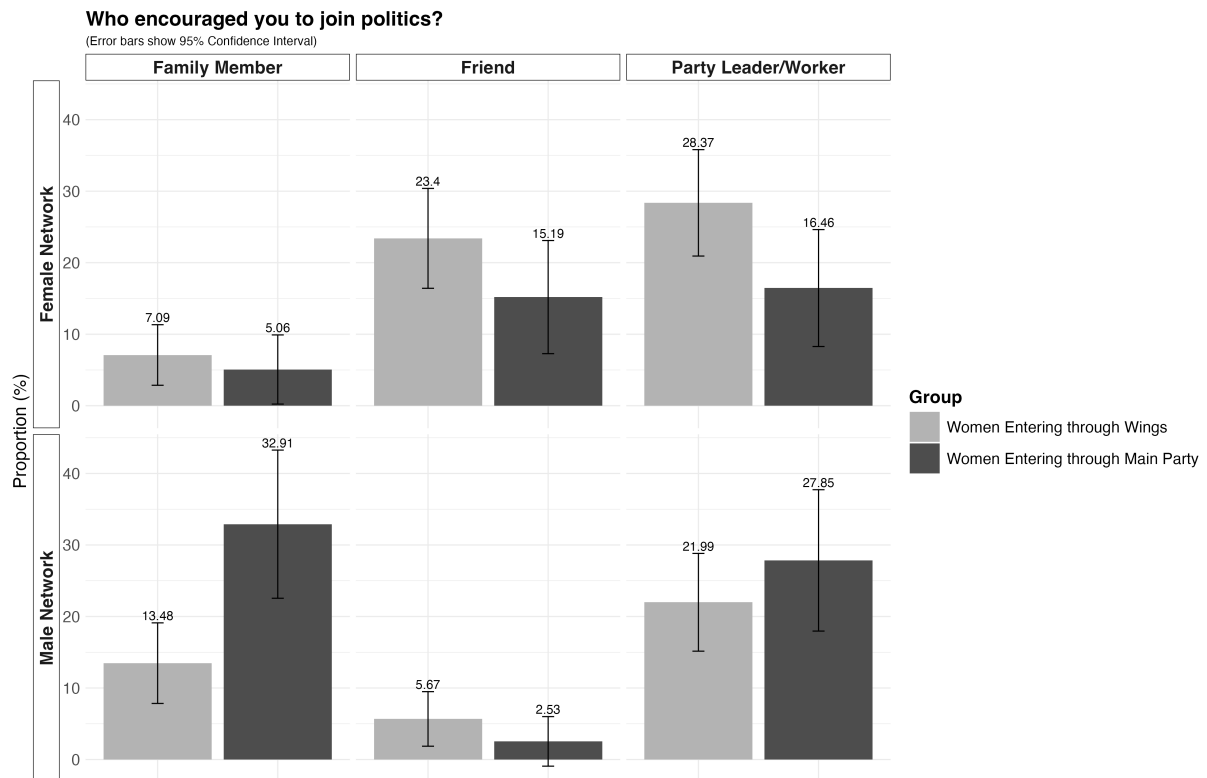


Figure SI.6: Differences in Women's Entry Networks

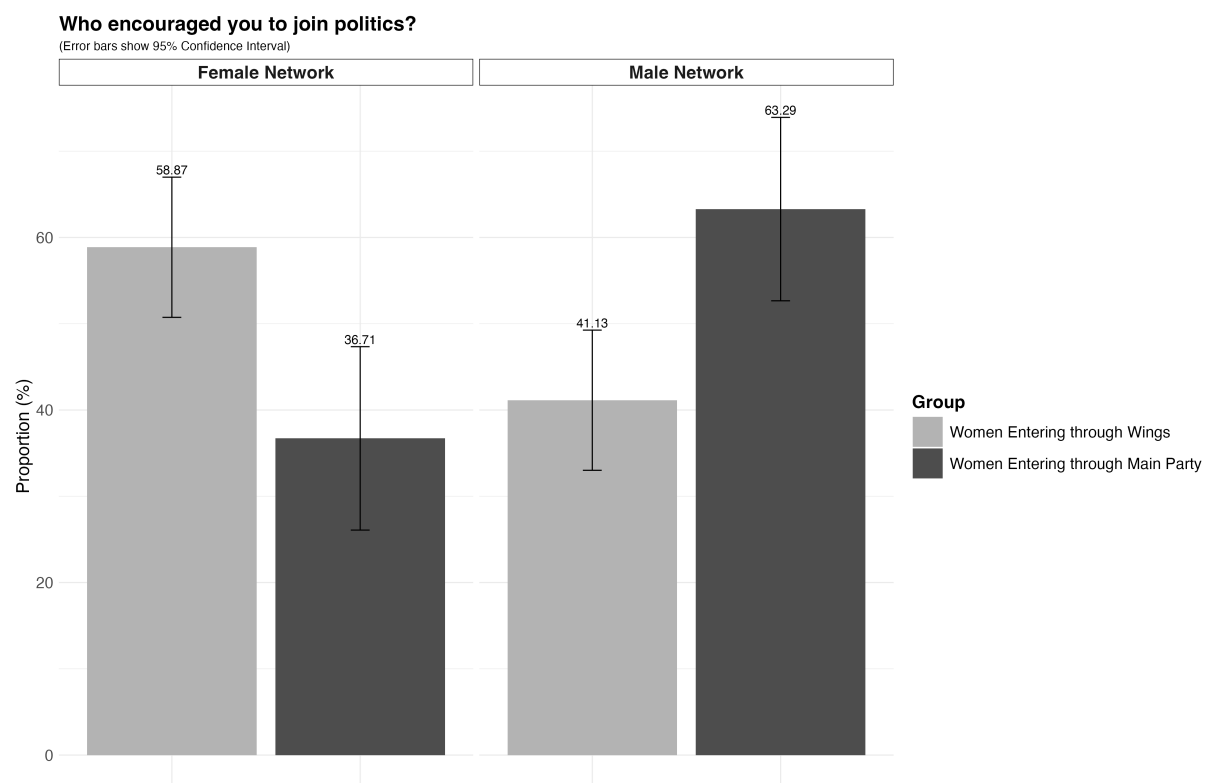


Figure SI.7: Political Entry Networks for Women in the Main Party Versus Wing

## G Promotion Patterns in Survey Sample

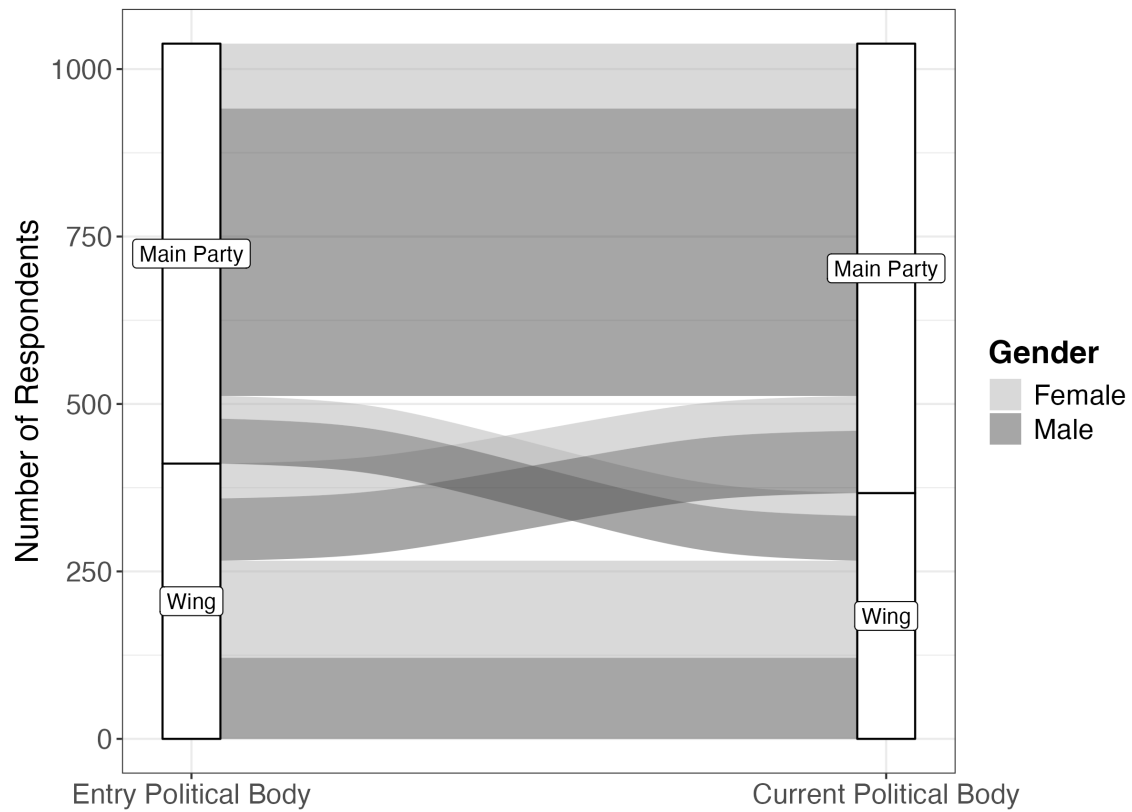


Figure SI.8: Political Entry and Promotions for Elites Surveyed

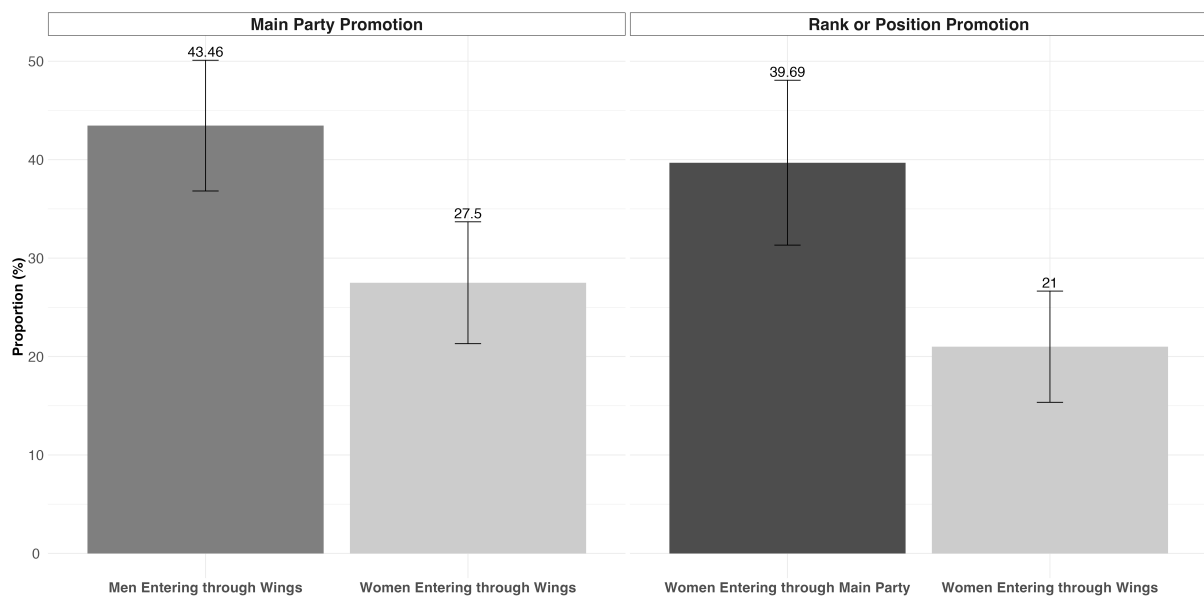


Figure SI.9: Promotion Patterns for Various Groups in Survey Sample

G.1 Promotion Patterns by Party

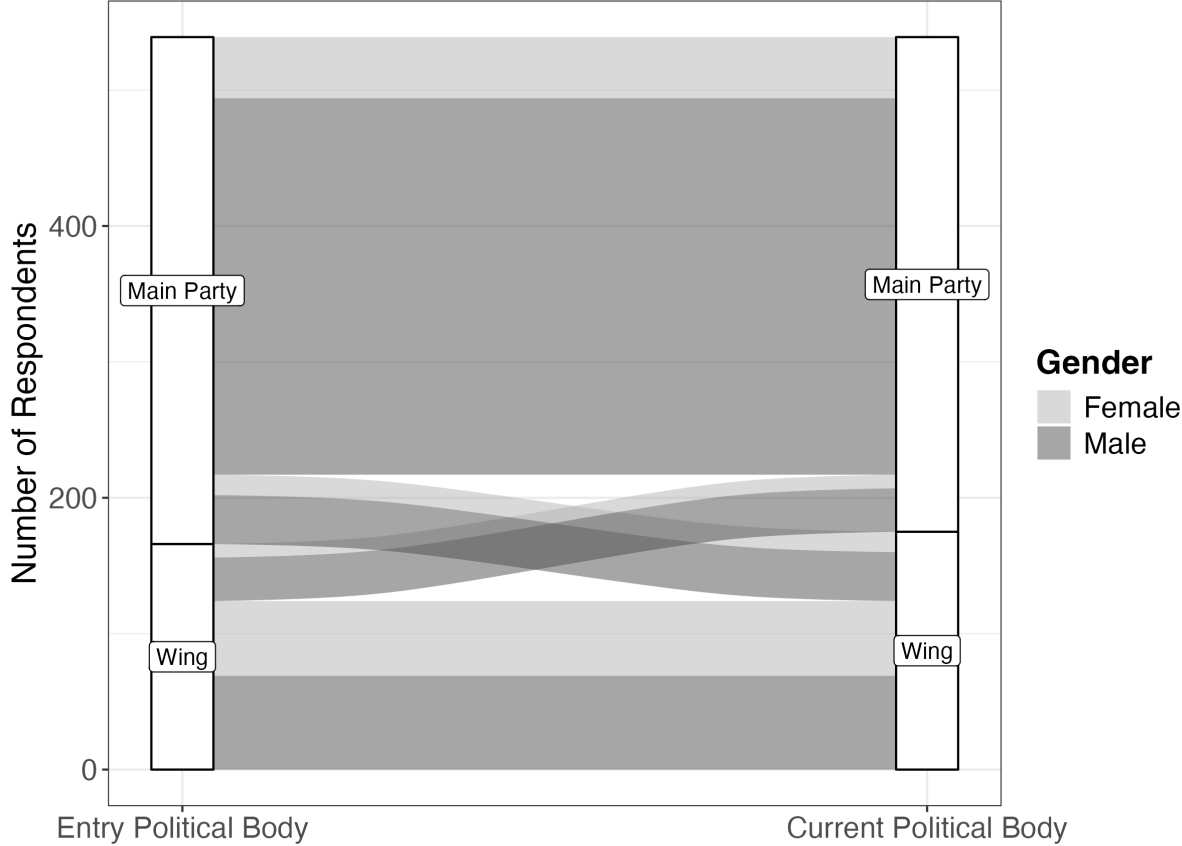


Figure SI.10: Career Transitions for AAP Respondents

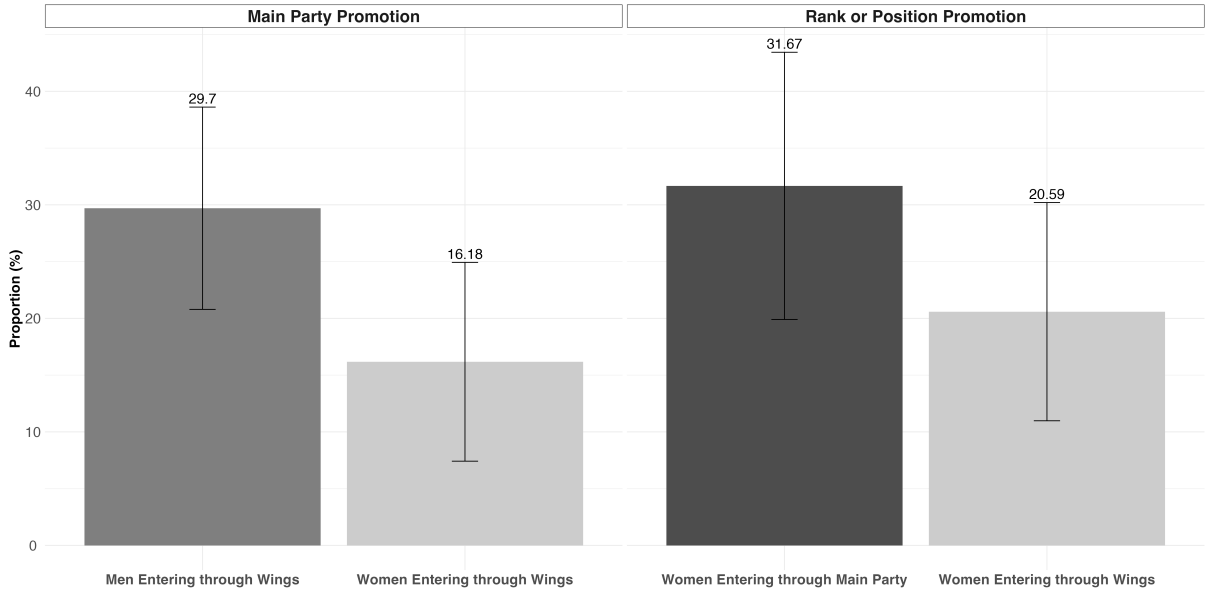


Figure SI.11: Promotion Patterns Among AAP Respondents

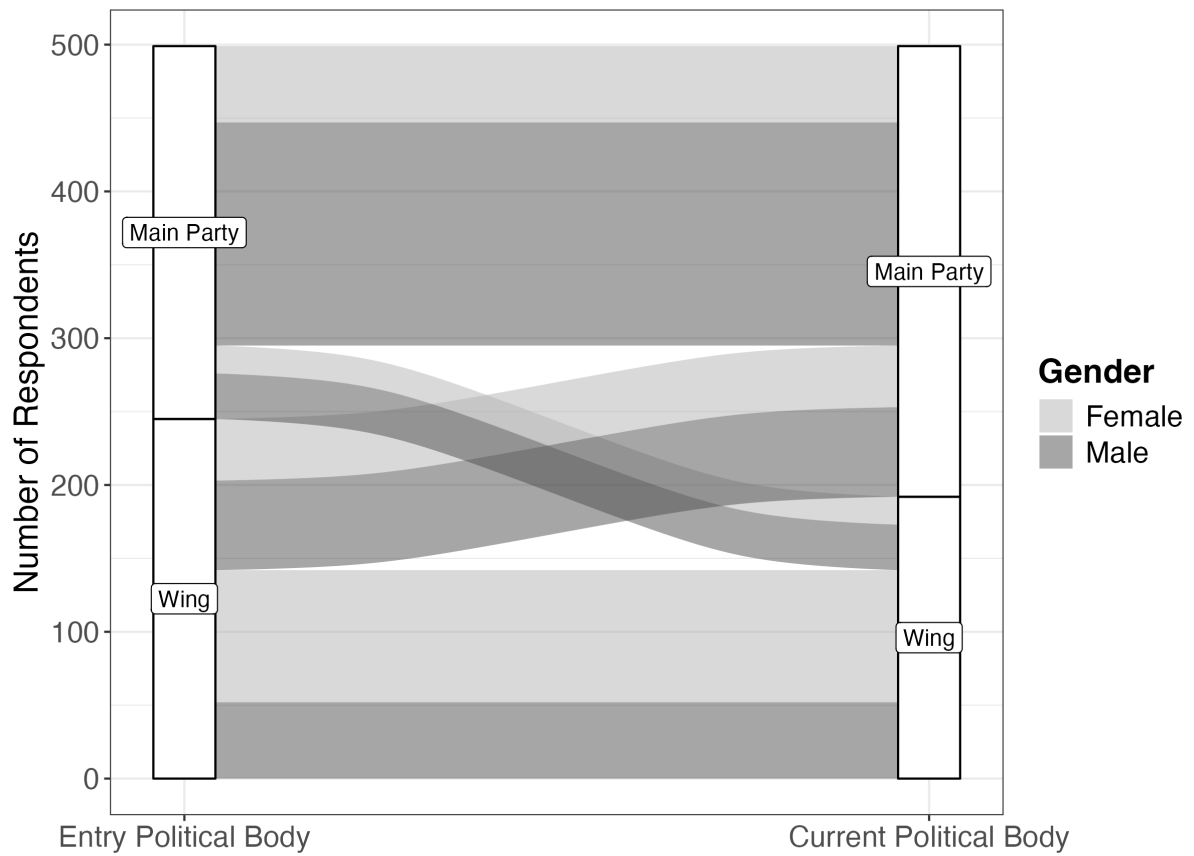


Figure SI.12: Career Transitions for BJP Respondents

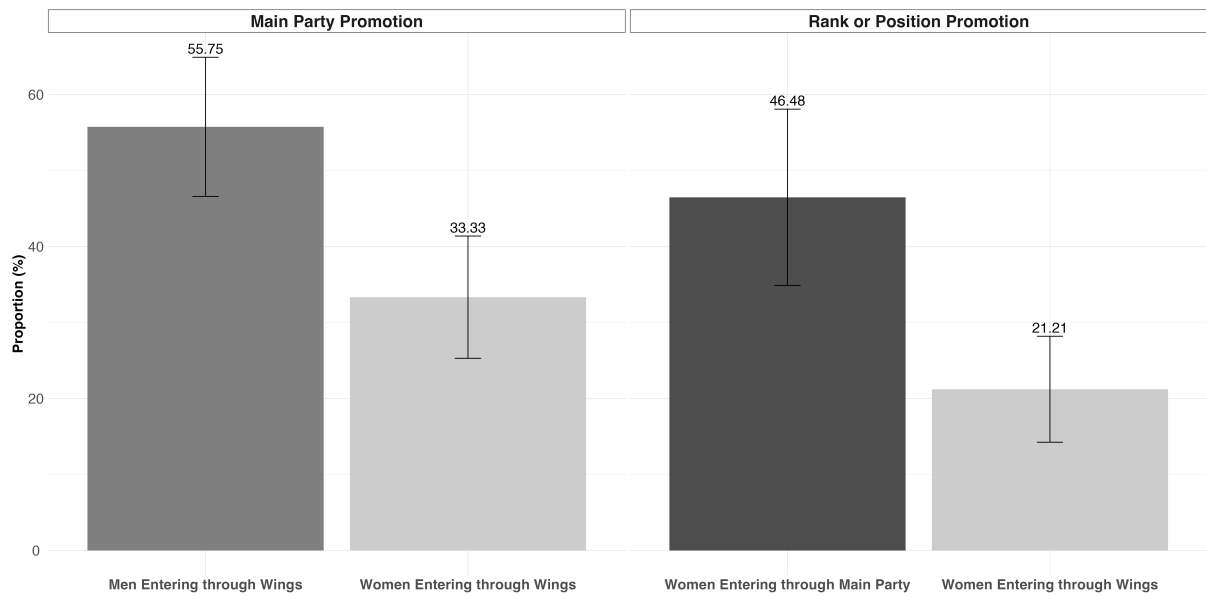


Figure SI.13: Promotion Patterns Among BJP Respondents

# H Party Work

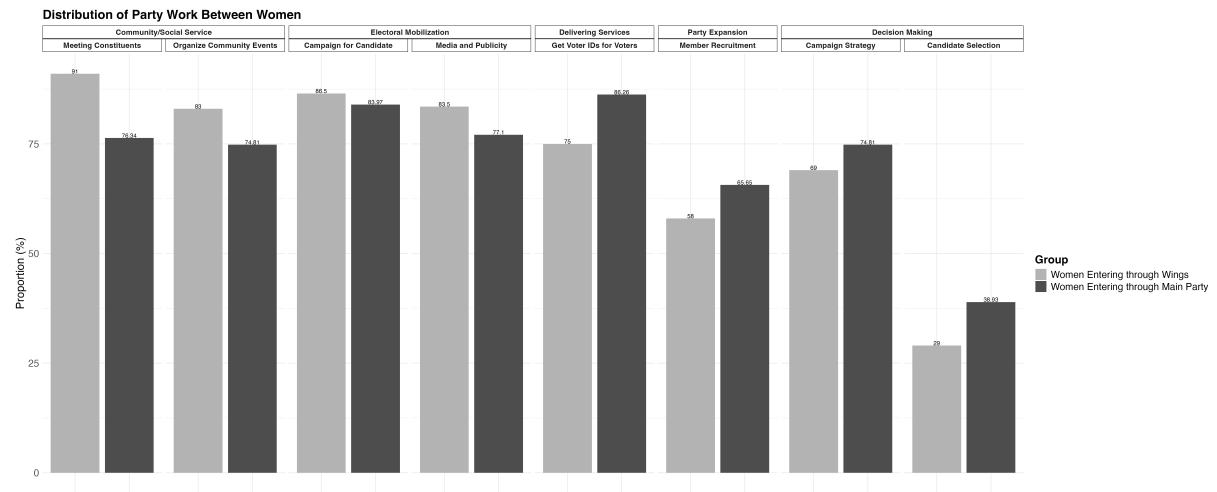


Figure SI.14: Party Work Performed by Women in the Wings and Main Party Organization

# I Sociopolitical Capital Gaps

Figure SI.15: Sociopolitical Gaps between Women's Wing and Main Party Women

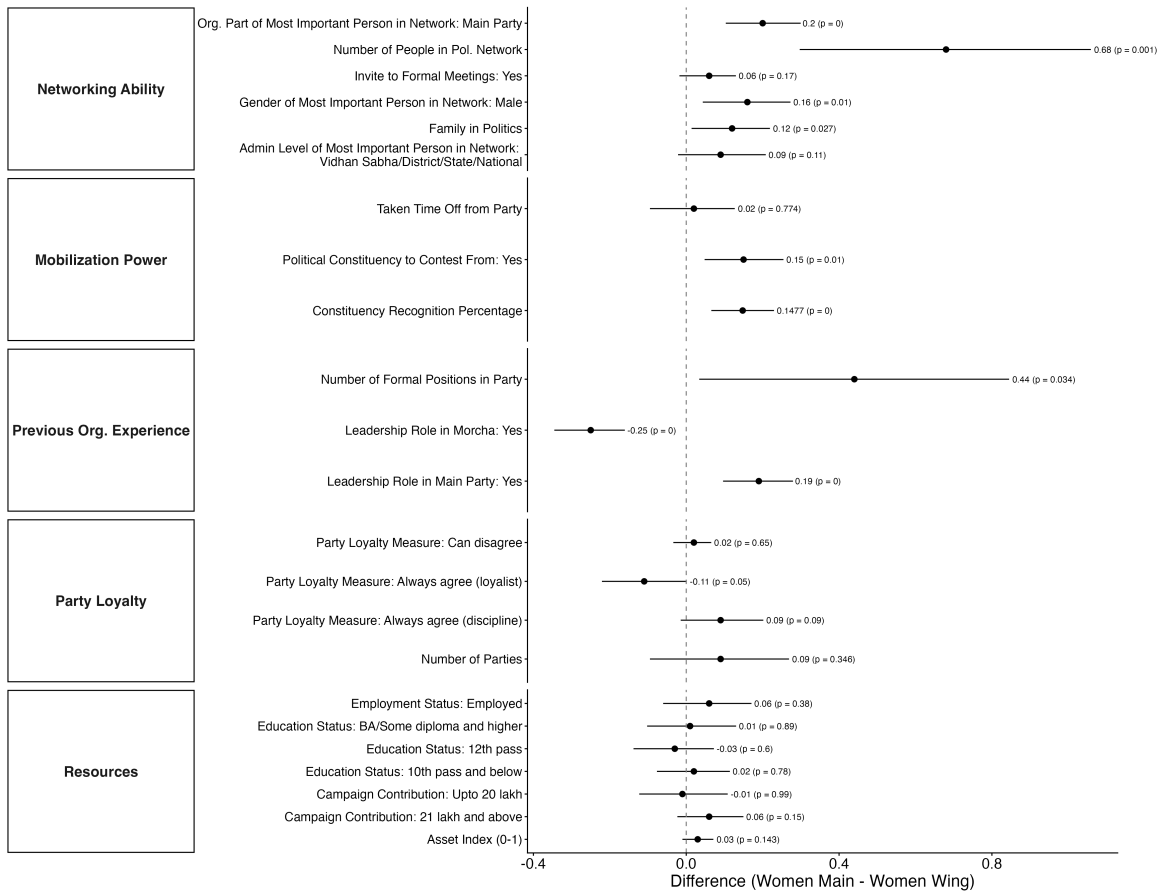
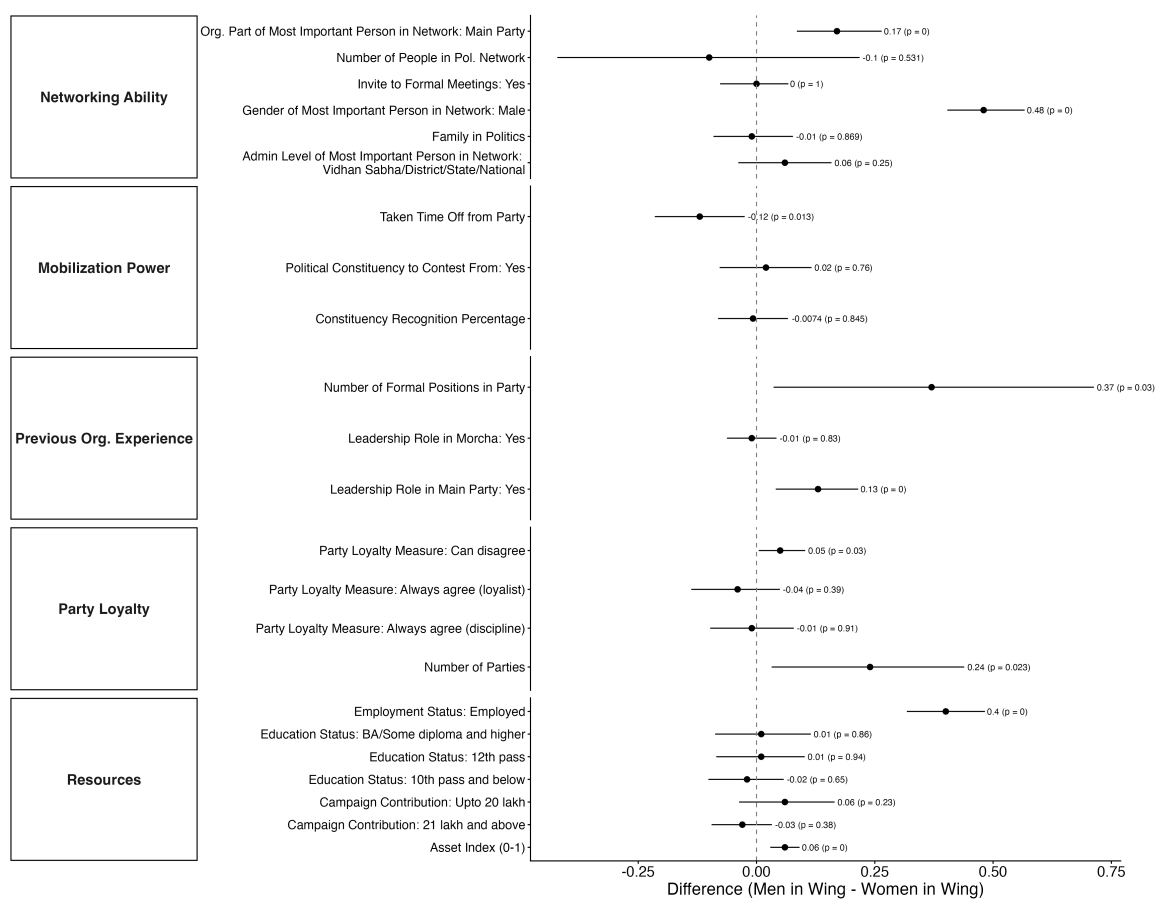


Figure SI.16: Sociopolitical Gaps between Women's Wing Women and Party Wing Men



## J Outright Bias: Average Marginal Component Effects

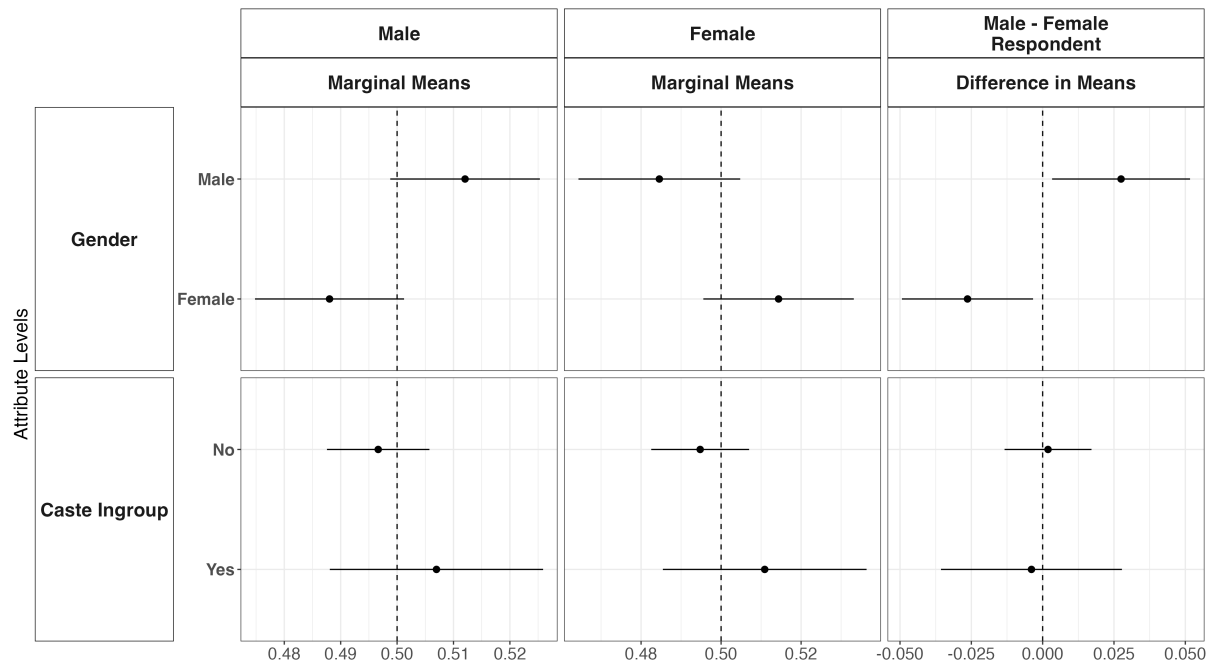


Figure SI.17: Gender Bias Among Elites

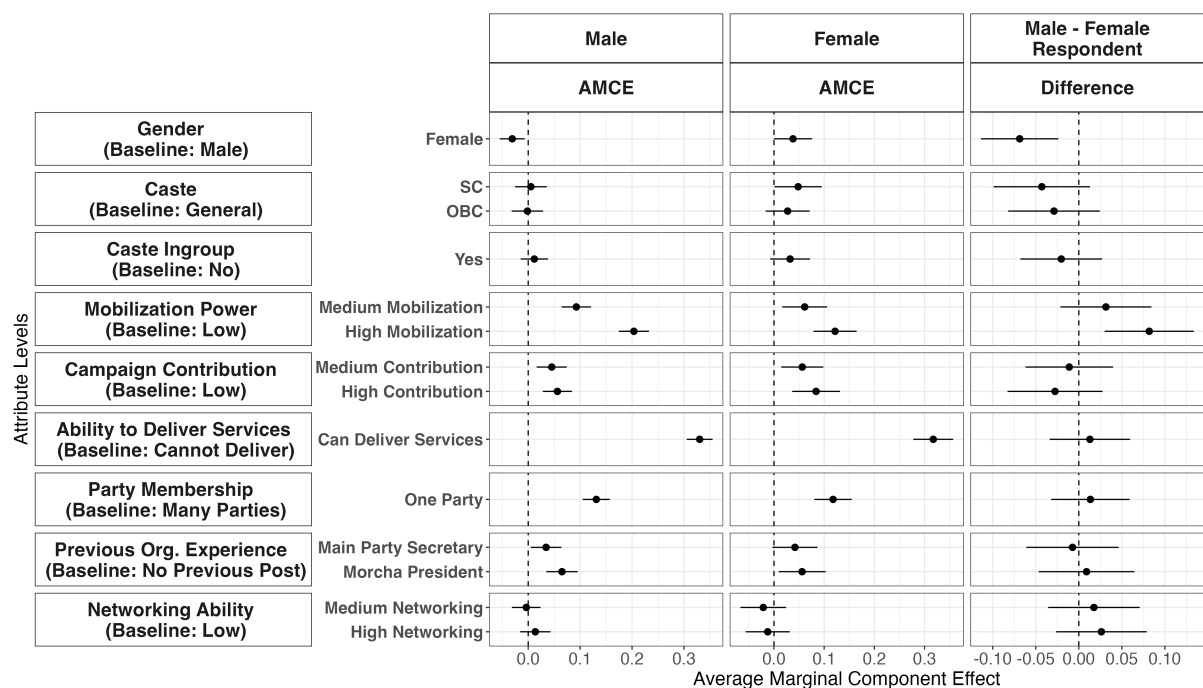


Figure SI.18: Average Marginal Component Effects and Differences in AMCEs between Male and Female Respondents

## K Gendered Promotion Criteria: Average Marginal Means

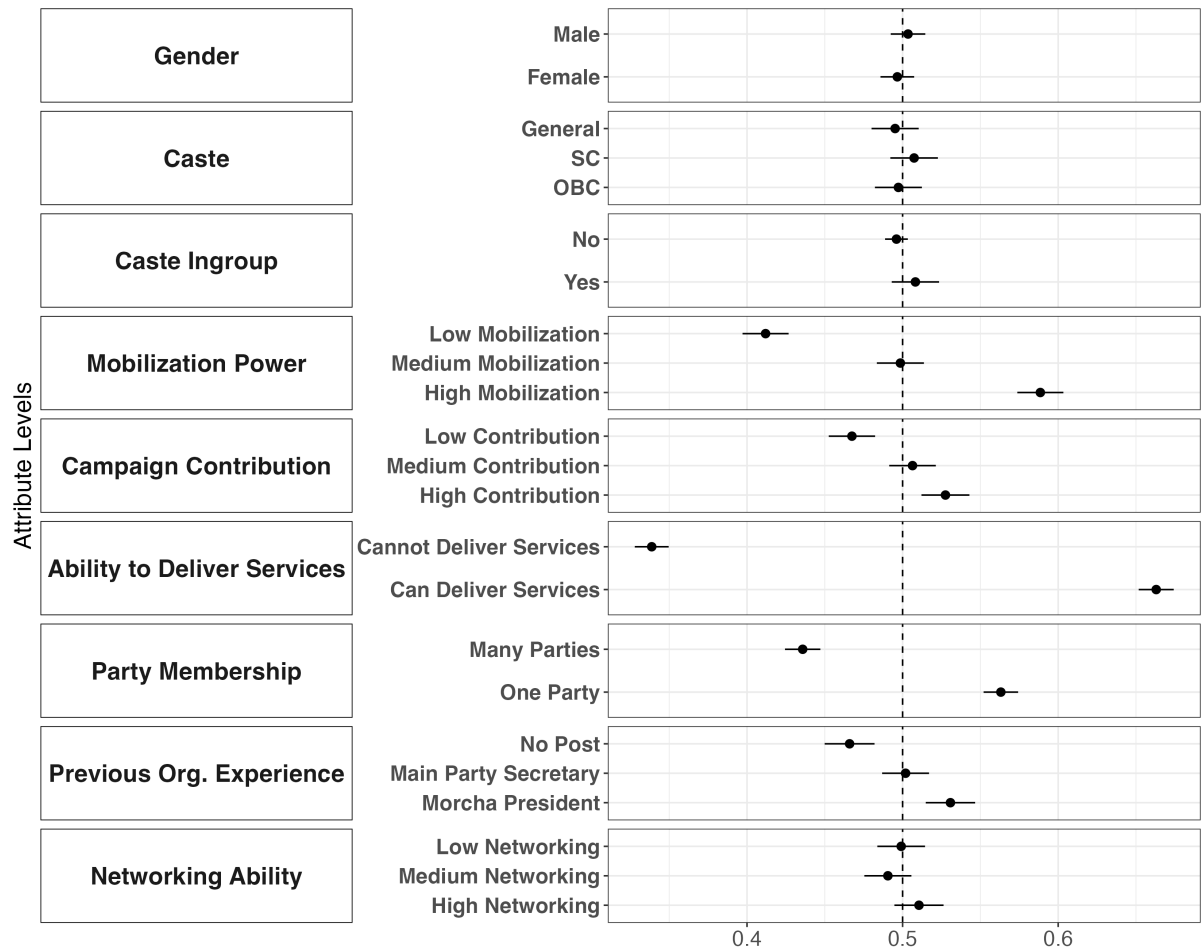


Figure SI.19: Average Marginal Means of Attributes Influencing Promotion

## L Heterogeneous Effects by Respondent Gender

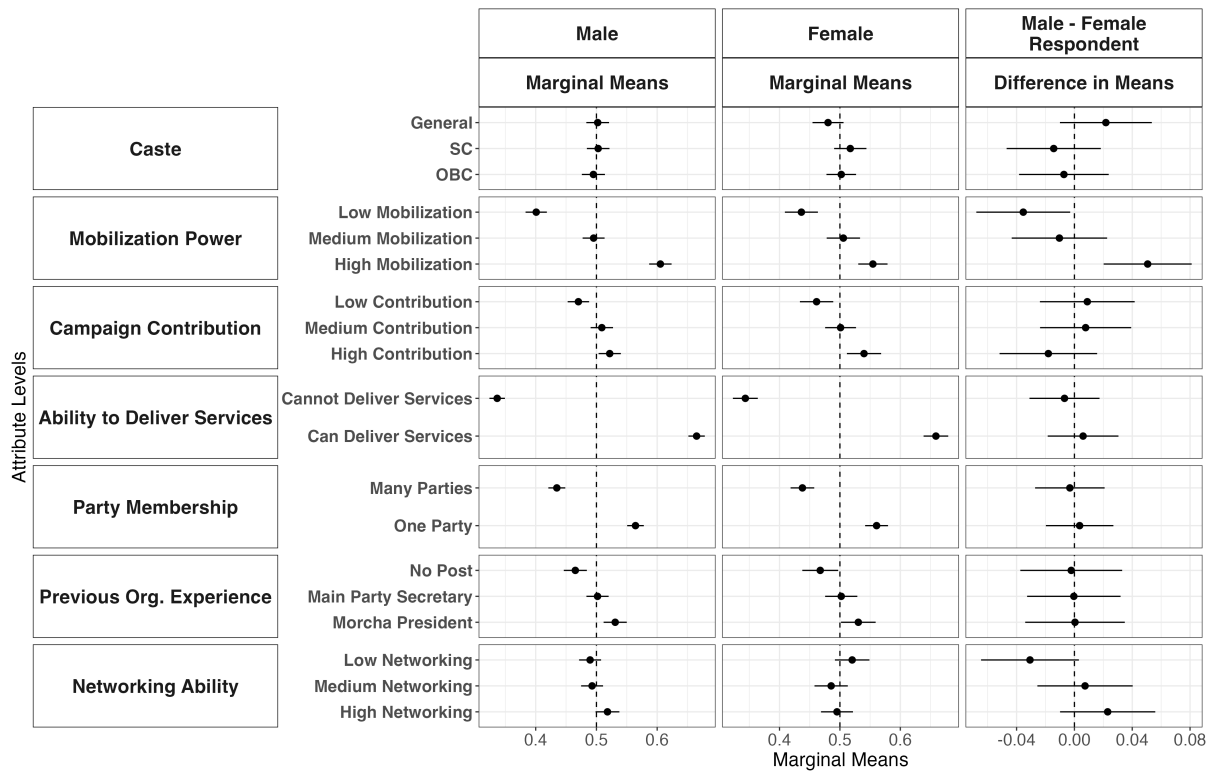


Figure SI.20: Difference in Preferences by Respondent Gender (AMM)

## M Heterogeneous Effects by Respondent Party

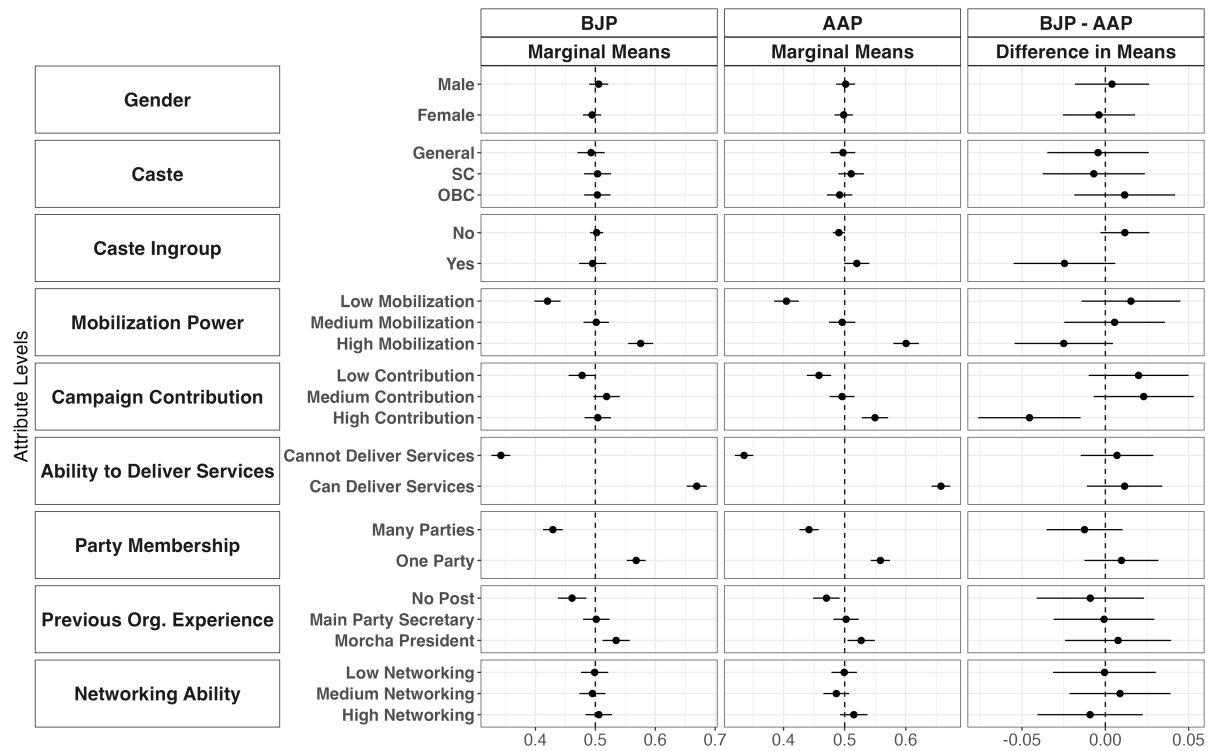


Figure SI.21: Difference in Preferences by Respondent Party

# N Heterogeneous Effects by Respondent Party and Gender

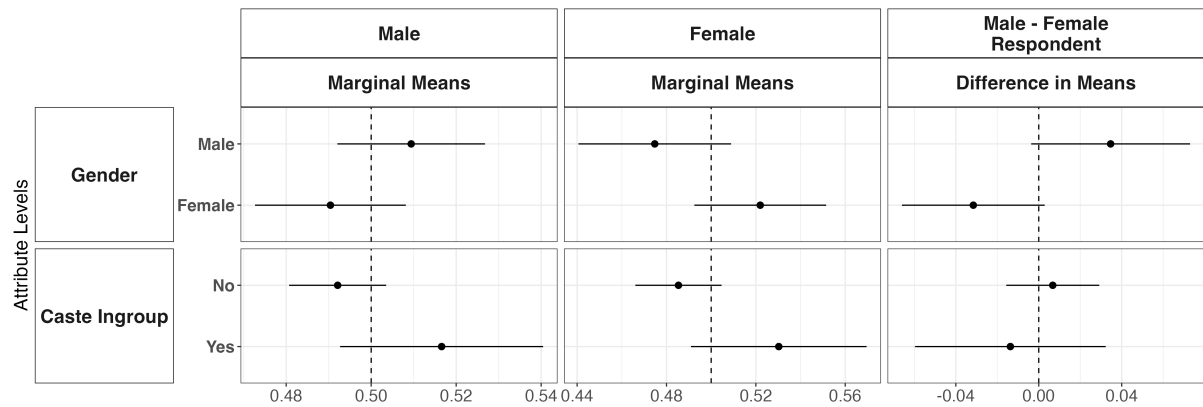


Figure SI.22: Difference in Preferences by Respondent Gender in AAP

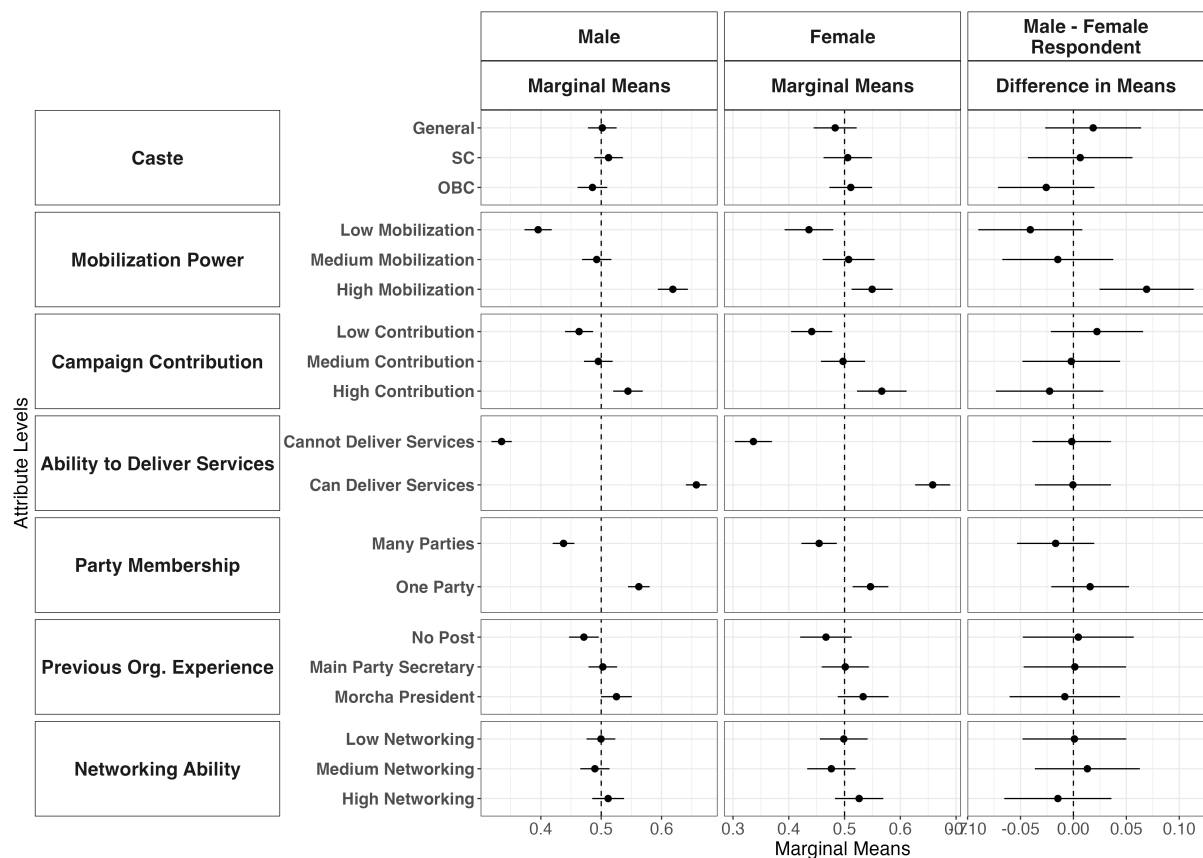


Figure SI.23: Difference in Preferences by Respondent Gender in AAP

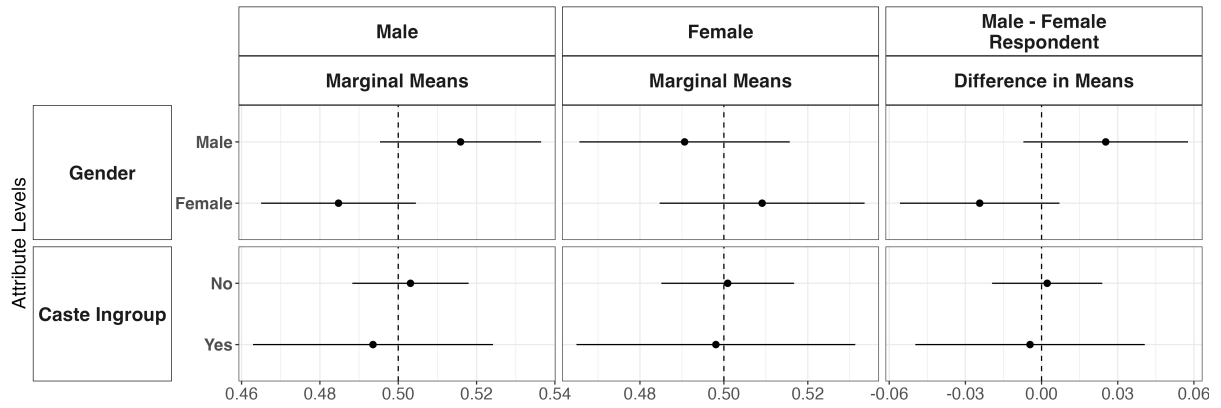


Figure SI.24: Difference in Preferences by Respondent Gender in BJP

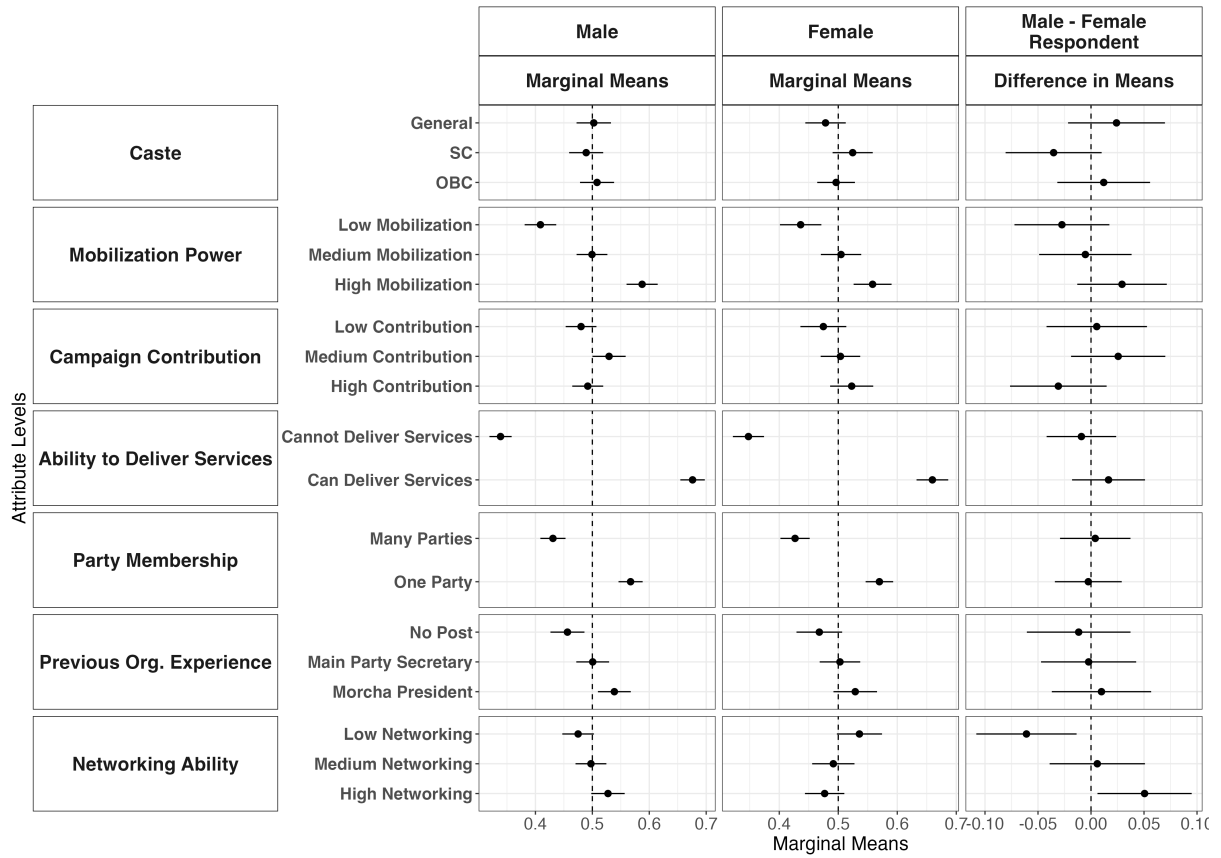


Figure SI.25: Difference in Preferences by Respondent Gender in BJP

## O Effect of Attributes on Promotion Among Male Respondents

I interacted the candidate profile's gender with all other attributes among male respondents. This tested whether female candidate profiles were adjudicated more harshly for promotion relative to male candidate profiles. While many difference in means estimates are not statistically significant, they generally lie to the left of the dashed line. This indicates that equally (un)qualified women are less likely to be considered favorably for promotion relative to men. This bias is more pronounced when both profiles are less qualified.

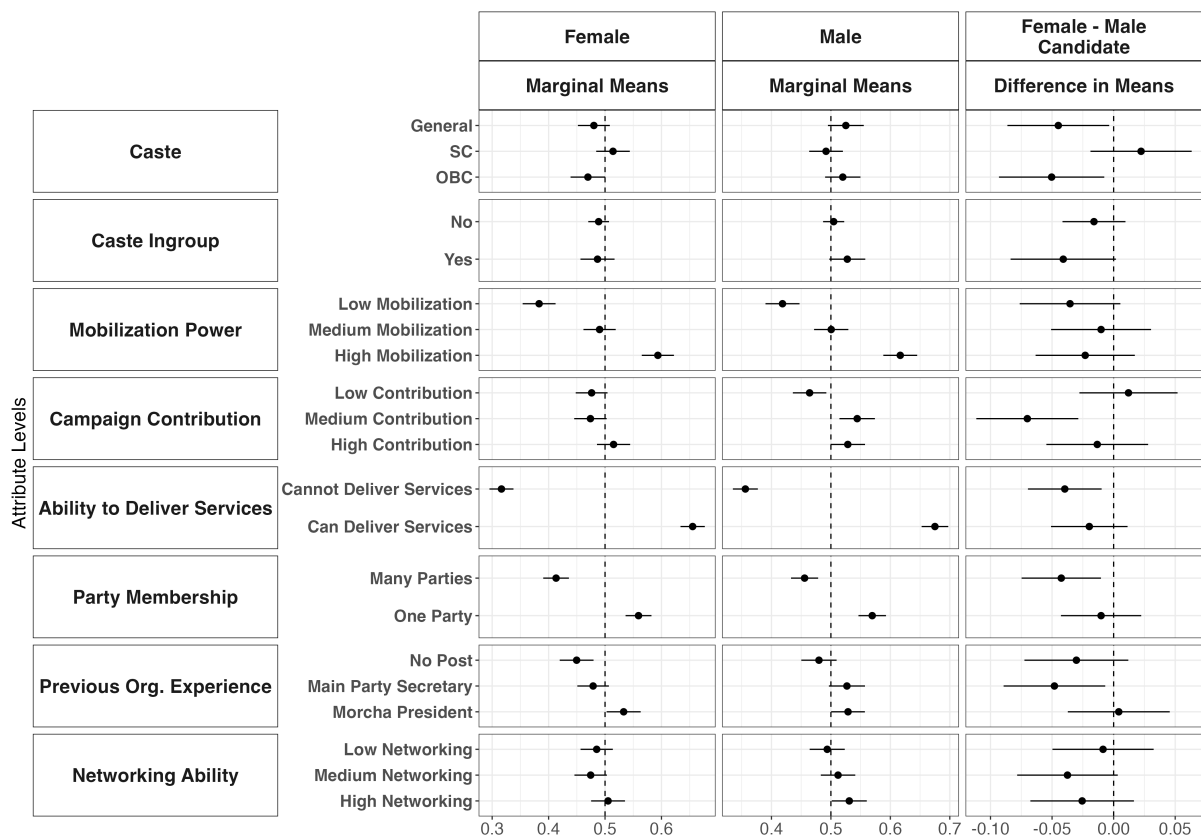


Figure SI.26: Average Marginal Means for Interaction Between Gender and All Other Attributes Among Male Respondents

## P Descriptive Results for Selection Traits

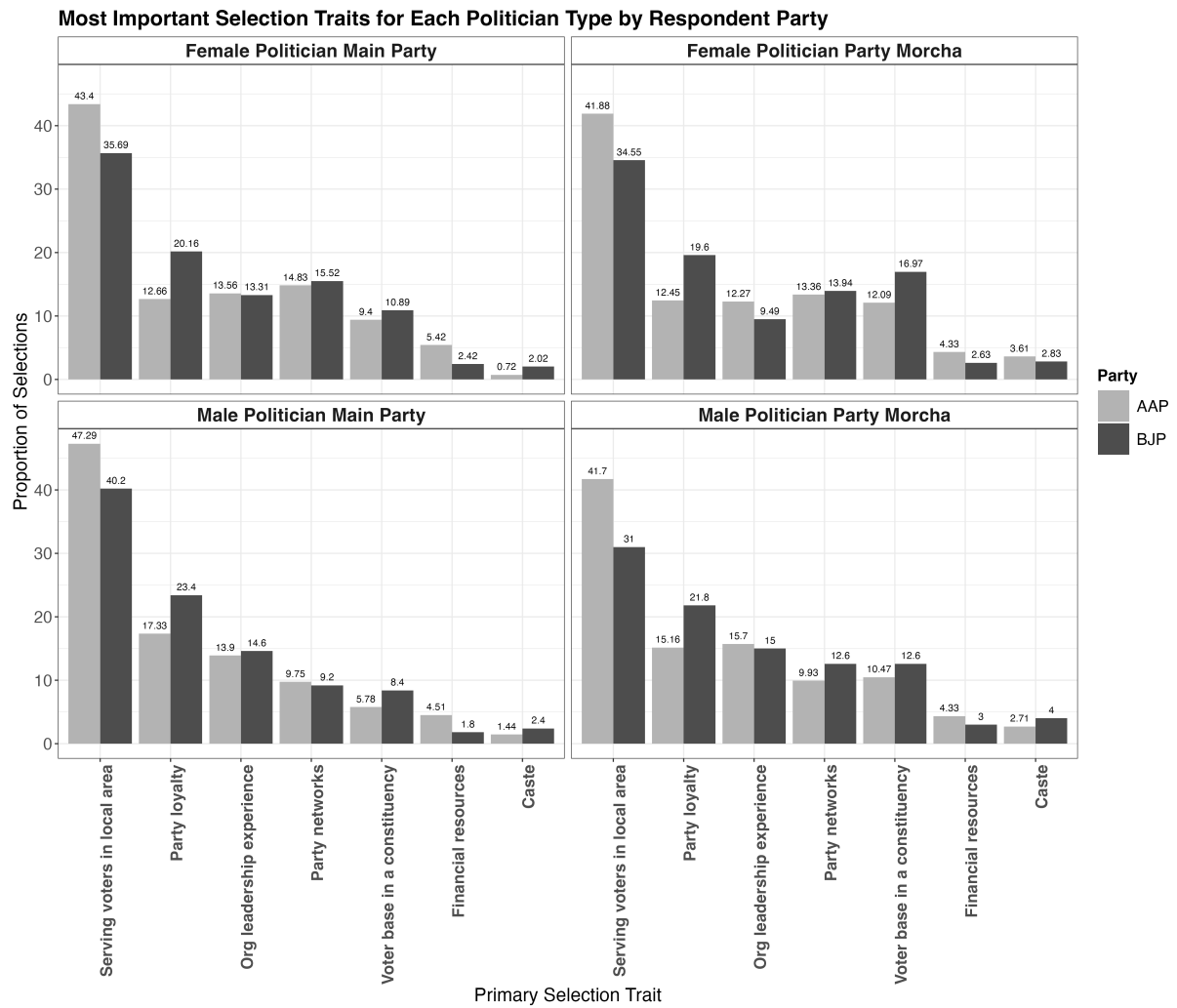


Figure SI.27: Descriptive Results for Selection Traits by Respondent Party

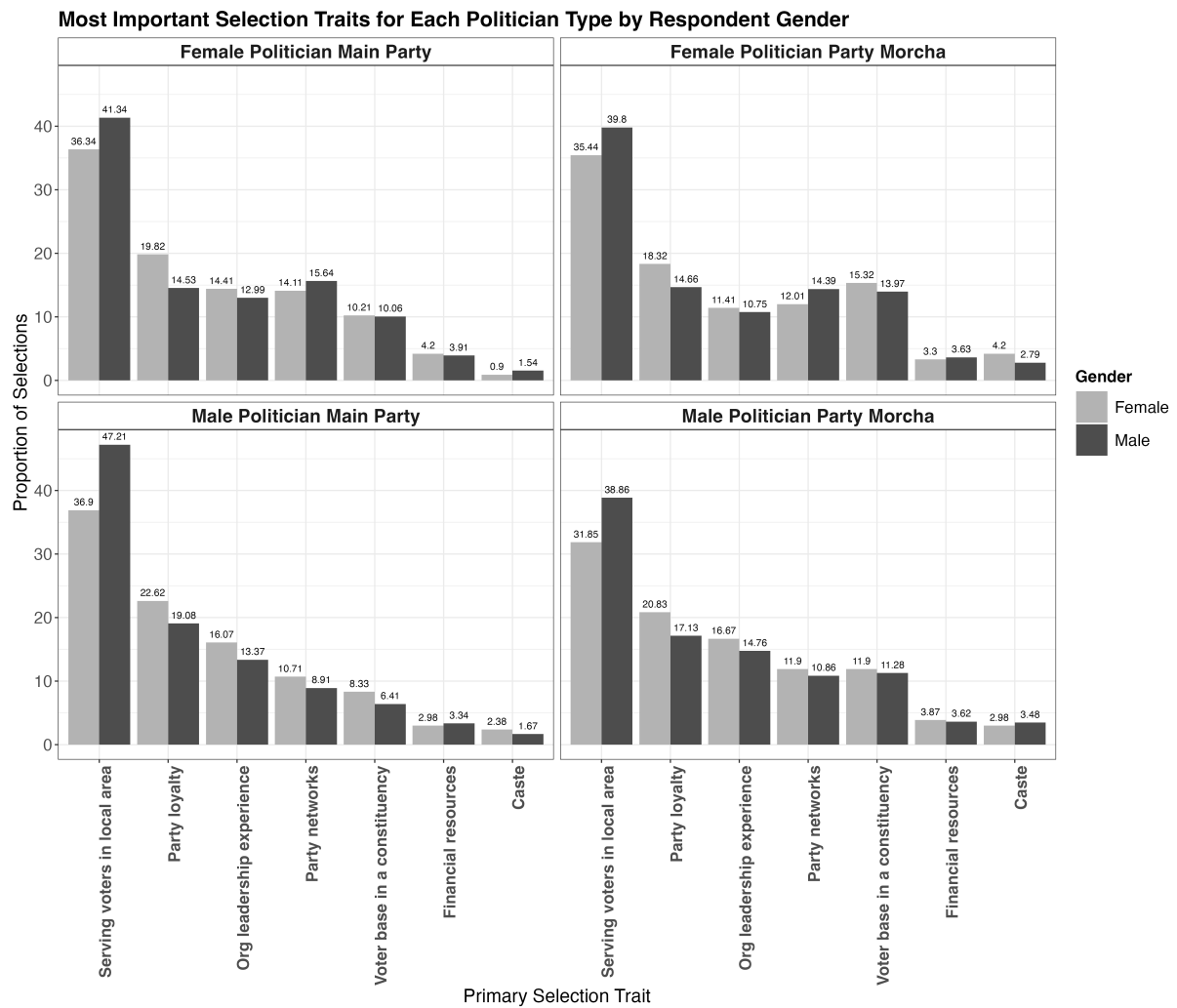


Figure SI.28: Descriptive Results for Selection Traits by Party Leader Gender

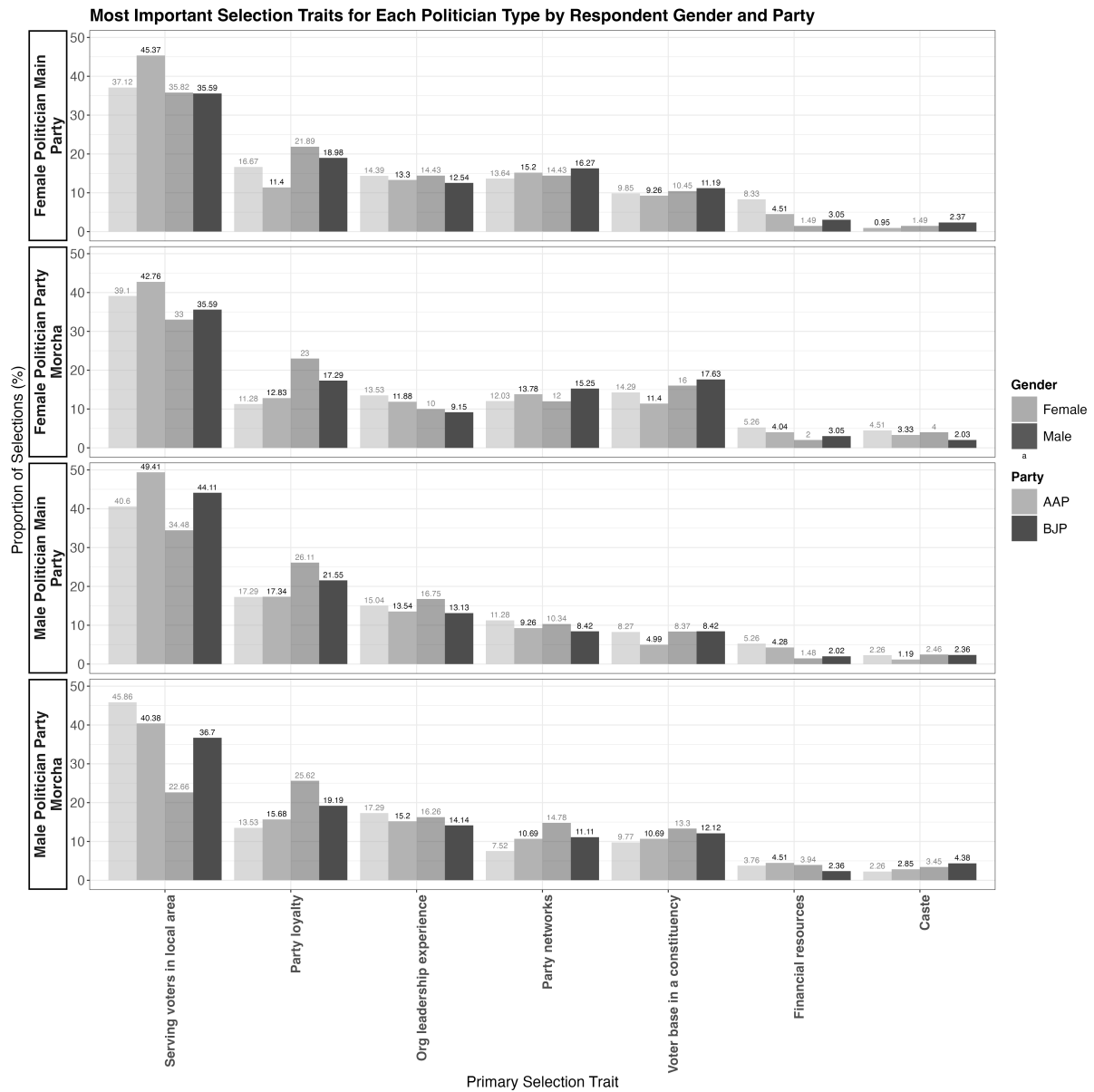


Figure SI.29: Descriptive Results for Selection Traits by Elite Gender and Party

## Q Political Ambition Among Respondents

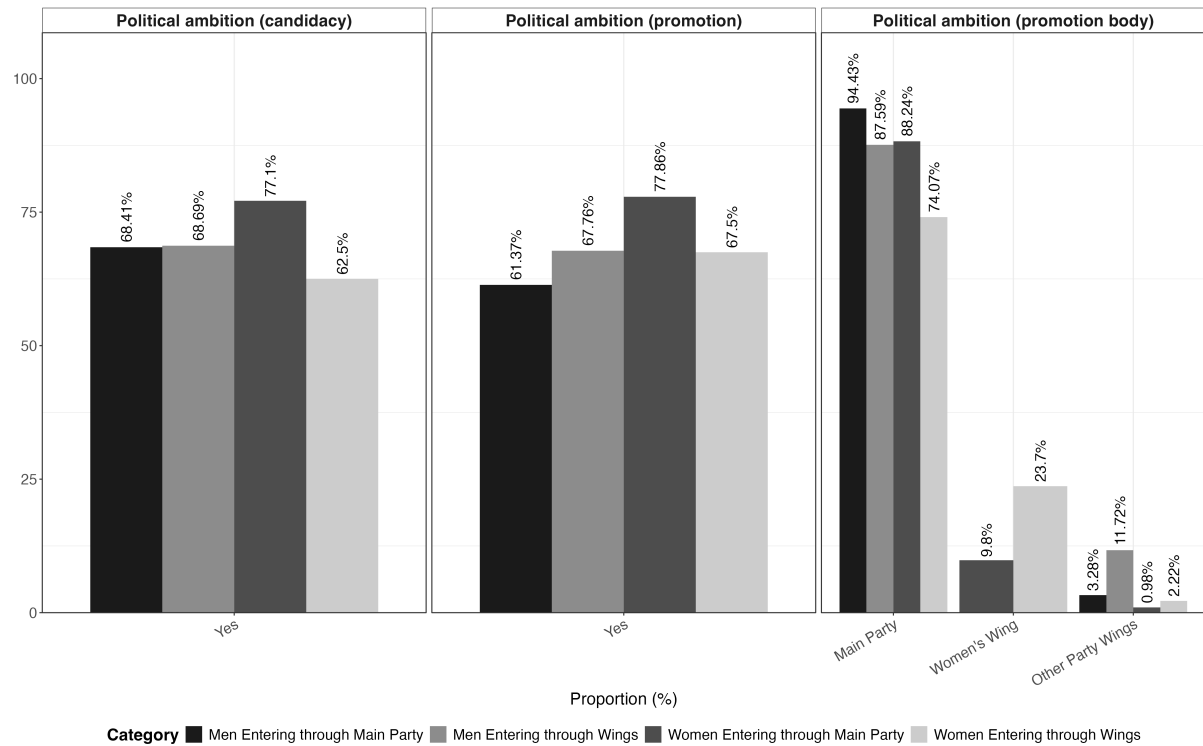


Figure SI.30: Political Ambition by Party Organization